

XYZ

C O R P O R A T I O N

Manager Handbook

The practice guide for people managers — judgment, craft and conversation for the decisions policy cannot make for you.

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This handbook does not state policy. Every rule, entitlement, threshold and legal requirement governing employment at XYZ Corporation lives in the Employee Handbook; every security control lives in the Information Security Manual. This document deliberately does not restate either of them. What it adds is the layer neither can supply: how a manager prepares, reasons, decides and speaks once the rule is already known. Where a rule applies, this handbook points to it and stops.

How This Handbook Works

Three documents govern your work as a manager. They do different jobs, and knowing which one you are in saves you from the two most common manager errors — inventing a rule that already exists, and following a rule where judgment was required.

The three documents, and the division of labour between them

Document	What it is for	When you reach for it
Employee Handbook Rev. 4.0	The policy authority . Entitlements, thresholds, prohibitions, statutory obligations, standard operating procedures, forms and the state-by-state compliance tables. If the question is " <i>what is the rule?</i> " the answer is there and only there.	Before you commit to anything. Any time you are about to state a rule out loud.

Information Security Manual XYZ-ISMS-MAN-001	The control authority . Access provisioning and revocation, joiner-mover-leaver mechanics, screening gates, retention, incident handling, awareness training and the evidence each control must produce.	Whenever someone joins your team, changes role, leaves it, or asks for access to something.
Manager Handbook This document	The practice guide . How to think, prepare, decide and speak. Diagnostics, decision tests, drafting craft, conversation structure, worked examples, failure patterns and rehearsal language.	Once you know the rule and still do not know what to do — which is most of the time.

A DELIBERATE OMISSION

This handbook contains no entitlement figures, no accrual tables, no statutory thresholds, no notice periods, no state-by-state comparison charts and no SOP step lists. Those exist, are maintained, and are authoritative elsewhere. Duplicating them here would create a second version that drifts out of date, and a manager who quotes a stale number to an employee has created a problem rather than solved one. Where you need a number, this handbook tells you where the number lives.

What is actually in here

Six things that the policy documents structurally cannot contain, because policy describes obligations and this describes performance of a craft:

- **Diagnostics** — structured ways to work out what kind of problem you are looking at before you choose a response. Most manager errors are misdiagnosis, not mishandling.
- **Decision tests** — questions you put to your own reasoning to find the flaw in it before someone else does.
- **Drafting craft** — how to write a scorecard, a note to file, a promotion case, a corrective action narrative, a coverage plan, so that the document does the job it was written for.
- **Conversation architecture** — the shape of a hard conversation, the opening sentence, what to do when it goes sideways, and what to do the following week.
- **Failure patterns** — the specific, recurring ways managers create legal exposure, attrition and unfairness, drawn from what actually goes wrong.
- **Rehearsal language** — sentences you can borrow. Not scripts to read, but a starting point so that you are not composing under pressure.

How to read the boxes

Say it like this	Language you can borrow. Adapt the words; keep the structure and the order.
Judgment call	A genuine fork where reasonable managers differ. The box gives you the considerations, not the answer.
Failure mode	A specific, common, expensive mistake. Read these even if you skim everything else.
Practice tool	A template, checklist or drill you can use directly.
Location trigger	Something that changes your behaviour because of where the employee sits. Chapter 14 covers California and New York in full.
Where the rule lives	A pointer into the Employee Handbook or Information Security Manual. Follow it rather than relying on memory.

A note on tone

Managing people is a skill, not a personality trait, and nobody arrives good at it. This handbook assumes you are competent, busy, and occasionally out of your depth — which is the ordinary condition of the job. It does not assume you have read it cover to cover. Each chapter stands alone and repeats nothing from the others except by cross-reference.

Two habits underlie everything that follows. First, **write things down when they happen**, not when they become a problem; almost every chapter here is easier if you did. Second, **ask early**. Your People Partner would rather have a five-minute conversation now than a three-week investigation later, and there is no version of this job where asking makes you look worse than guessing.

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PART ONE · THE PRACTICE OF MANAGING

1 · What You Actually Decide

New managers routinely believe they have less authority than they do in the areas that matter most, and more than they do in the areas that carry legal weight. Getting this the right way round is the first skill.

The inversion

Ask a manager six months into the job what they control, and you will usually hear a list of things they do not: salary bands, headcount, titles, the review calendar, the tooling. Ask them what they defer on, and you will hear a list of things they should not be deciding alone: whether a complaint is serious enough to escalate, whether an absence counts, whether a warning is warranted.

The inversion is understandable. The constrained things are visible and frustrating; the constrained things you *should* defer on feel like ordinary judgment calls. But the areas where the Company removes your discretion are precisely the areas where an individual manager's good instincts are not enough — because consistency across hundreds of managers is itself the legal protection, and no single manager can see the pattern.

Meanwhile the areas where you have almost unlimited discretion — how work is distributed, who gets the interesting problem, whose name is in the room, how often you meet, how you respond when someone brings you bad news — are the ones that actually determine whether your team performs and stays. Nobody will stop you exercising them. Nobody will remind you to.

The three registers of a manager decision

Before acting, work out which of three registers you are in. This takes about four seconds once the habit forms and prevents most avoidable damage.

Register	What it means	How to recognise it
Yours	You decide, you own the outcome, and consulting is optional. Nobody is going to review it. The quality of the decision is entirely a function of how much thought you put in.	It concerns work design, attention, opportunity, sequencing, tone, or how you spend your own time. No entitlement, no record, no adverse consequence for the employee.
Yours, after a conversation	You still decide, but the decision is materially better and materially safer after someone with a wider view has tested it. The conversation is not permission-seeking; it is calibration.	It creates a written record about a person; it treats two people differently; it changes someone's scope, standing or pay expectation; or you notice you are irritated.
Not yours	The decision belongs to People, Legal, Compensation, Leave Administration, Accommodations or Security. Your job is to recognise the trigger fast and route it accurately, not to form a view.	Health, disability, religion, pregnancy, family care, pay for anyone but yourself to explain, a complaint of any kind, classification, security incidents, or anything that ends someone's employment.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

The definitive list of what a manager must never do alone, and the five obligations that carry no discretion at all, is in the Employee Handbook, Part XVII §129. Read it once properly and then rely on the register test above to tell you when to go back to it. This handbook does not reproduce that list.

Authority you have and rarely use

The following are entirely within an ordinary manager's gift, cost nothing to approve, and are chronically under-exercised. If you are looking for leverage, start here rather than with the things you cannot change.

- **Reassigning work.** You can move a project from someone who is coasting on it to someone who would be stretched by it, this week, without asking anyone. This is the single most powerful development tool you have and it is free.
- **Changing your own meeting.** Cancelling a status meeting, halving a recurring call, moving a decision to a written document — all yours. Managers frequently campaign upward for time they could recover downward in an afternoon.
- **Deciding what "done" means.** A great deal of overwork comes from ambiguity about the standard, not from the volume. You can set the standard explicitly and lower it where the work does not warrant more.
- **Who is in the room.** Bringing a junior person to a meeting they would learn from, or having someone present their own work rather than presenting it for them, costs you nothing and changes trajectories.
- **Protecting focus.** You can absorb an interruption, decline a request on your team's behalf, or push back on a deadline. Teams notice which managers do this. It is a major retention variable and it is invisible in every policy document.
- **Saying the specific thing.** Naming precisely what someone did well, in front of the person whose opinion they care about, is unlimited, untaxed and largely unused.

JUDGMENT CALL · USING YOUR DISCRETION TO COMPENSATE FOR A CONSTRAINT

You cannot give someone the raise they deserve this cycle. You *can* give them the visible project, the external presentation, the architecture decision, or the introduction. Is that a fair substitute?

Not permanently, and do not present it as one. But it is legitimate and often correct in the short term, on two conditions: you say plainly that it is not a substitute for compensation and that you are working the compensation question separately, and you actually work it. The failure mode is using opportunity as a sedative — loading someone with growth while quietly never raising their pay case. People forgive a constraint. They do not forgive being managed around.

The asymmetry of manager statements

An ordinary employee's offhand remark is an offhand remark. Yours is not. Three asymmetries apply to everything you say, and they are the reason experienced managers speak more carefully than they did as individual contributors:

- **What you know, the Company knows.** If someone mentions a problem to you in a corridor, the Company is on notice from that moment. "They only said it in passing" is not a defence; it is an aggravating fact.

- **What you say, someone may rely on.** "You'll be fine," "there's a promotion in this for you," "that's not a problem" — these get remembered with precision and repeated back with confidence.
- **What you write, someone may read aloud.** Not necessarily in litigation. Also in a calibration session, an investigation, a records request, or to the employee themselves.

None of this argues for silence or for stilted, defensive speech, which reads as evasion and destroys trust faster than a clumsy honest answer. It argues for one small habit: **distinguish out loud between what you know, what you think, and what you will find out.** "The rule is X" — only if you have checked. "My read is Y" — flagged as your read. "I don't know; I'll find out by Thursday" — and then do.

FAILURE MODE · THE REASSURING GUESS

An employee asks whether their upcoming absence will count against them. You are almost certain it will not, and they look anxious, so you say "no, don't worry about that." You were wrong about which category it fell into. Three months later the employee has arranged their affairs on the basis of what you said, is out of pocket, and now genuinely believes the Company misled them — because a manager did.

The correct answer took four more seconds: *"I don't want to guess on something that matters this much. Let me get you the right answer today."* Then route it. You lose nothing by not knowing. You lose a great deal by being confidently wrong.

PART ONE · THE PRACTICE OF MANAGING

2 · The Four Questions

A single reusable test to run before any decision that affects a person. It takes under a minute and catches the large majority of manager errors before they leave your head.

Question one — What do I actually know?

Separate observation from inference, ruthlessly. Most manager decisions that go wrong go wrong here, before any process is involved.

What you observed	What you inferred and then treated as observed
Three deliverables late in six weeks; two without advance notice.	"They've checked out."
Said little in the last four team meetings; contributed substantially in writing afterwards.	"They're not engaged" / "they lack presence."
Pushed back hard on the plan in front of the customer.	"They're not a team player."
Declined two evening calls in a month.	"They're not committed."
Their peer's project shipped; theirs slipped.	"They're the weaker of the two."

The right-hand column is where discrimination claims, unfair ratings and needless resignations live. Not because the inferences are always wrong — some will be right — but because they are untested, they are usually driven by something other than the evidence, and they cannot be discussed with the person. You can put the left-hand column to someone. There is no useful conversation to be had about the right-hand column.

The forcing device: write the sentence you would say to the person. If it contains a characterisation rather than a fact and a date, you are not ready.

Question two — What else could explain this?

Generate at least three alternative explanations before settling on one. Not as an exercise in generosity, but because the first explanation that arrives is almost always the one that requires nothing of you.

Someone's output drops. Candidate explanations: they have disengaged; they are overloaded and have not said so; the work changed and they have not been retrained; a dependency they rely on has degraded; they are covering for a colleague on leave; they are dealing with something personal; the standard was never clear; or — commonly — you have unknowingly been giving them the least tractable problems.

These have completely different responses. Four of them are about you or the system. If you skip this question you will apply a performance response to a systems problem, which is both unfair and ineffective, and you will do it in writing.

PRACTICE TOOL · THE THREE-EXPLANATION RULE

Before your next difficult 1:1, write down three explanations for the behaviour, then open the conversation with the one that puts the least blame on the person: *"I want to check something with you — I've noticed X. Before I make anything of it, what's your read on what's going on?"*

You will be surprised how often the true explanation was not on your list at all.

Question three — Would I do this for anyone else on this team?

The comparator test, applied in both directions. Ask it about the decision you are making *and* about the decisions you have already made that you are not revisiting.

- Am I about to discipline this person for something I have tolerated in someone else?
- Am I about to make an exception I would not make for the person sitting next to them?
- If I extend this deadline / approve this trip / overlook this lapse, can I articulate why on grounds that apply to anyone in the same situation?
- Am I holding this person to a standard of communication, availability or style that I do not apply to my strongest performer?
- Have I given the person I find easier to talk to more of my time, and would the pattern be obvious to a third party?

Inconsistency is not merely unfair; it is the mechanism by which most successful discrimination claims are proved. A claimant rarely has evidence of intent. They very often have evidence that someone else did the same thing and nothing happened. You are the person who created that evidence, months earlier, by being reasonable in one case and firm in another for reasons you never wrote down.

FAILURE MODE · THE ACCUMULATED EXCEPTION

A strong performer has been habitually late to the stand-up for a year and you have let it go, reasonably, because the work is excellent. A weaker performer is late three times and you raise it formally.

You may be entirely right that the second case matters more — attendance for someone struggling has a different significance. But you have not written that reasoning down anywhere, and from the outside the pattern is that one person was excused and another was not. If the two people differ on any protected characteristic, the pattern is the case.

The fix is not to start disciplining your strong performer. It is to be explicit, in the moment and in writing, about why comparable-looking situations are being treated differently.

Question four — How does this read in six months, out of context?

Imagine your decision, and the message announcing it, being read by a stranger who does not know you, does not know the person, and does not have the surrounding conversation. This is not paranoia about litigation. It is the ordinary condition of every record you make: it will eventually be read by your successor, by a People Partner, by a calibration panel, or by the employee's next manager.

Three specific things to look at:

- **Timing.** What happened in the two months before this decision? If the answer includes a complaint, a leave request, an accommodation request, a pay discussion or a return from absence, your decision needs a documented history that predates it — or it needs to wait.
- **Consistency of stated reason.** Will the reason you are giving now match the reason in the review you wrote in January and the reason you will give if asked in December? A reason that changes over time is treated as evidence that none of the versions is true.
- **Proportion.** Does the severity of the response match the severity of the conduct, as a stranger would weigh it? A final warning for a first missed deadline reads as pretext, whatever the history in your head.

Applying the four questions under time pressure

The objection to all of this is that real decisions happen in corridors and Slack threads with ninety seconds of thought. True. Two responses.

First, the four questions compress. In practice they become: *what did I see, what else could it be, who else would I treat this way, and how does this look later?* That is genuinely under a minute once it is habitual.

Second — and more usefully — **almost nothing requires an immediate answer.** The number of people decisions that must be made within the hour is very close to zero, and the ones that feel urgent are usually urgent because someone else is uncomfortable, not because the situation is. Buying twenty-four hours is nearly always available and nearly always improves the outcome.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · BUYING TIME WITHOUT LOSING AUTHORITY

"That's a fair question and I don't want to give you a half-answer. Let me think about it properly and come back to you tomorrow."

"I want to sit with that before I respond. Can we put twenty minutes in for Thursday?"

"I'm not going to decide that in this meeting. I'll take it away and you'll hear from me by Friday."

Note what none of these do: apologise, hedge about whether you are allowed to decide, or promise a particular answer. And note the last element in each — a specific time. Buying time without naming a return date reads as avoidance, and you will have spent your credibility rather than your deadline.

PART ONE · THE PRACTICE OF MANAGING

3 · Working With Your People Partner

The most under-used relationship available to a manager. Managers who consult early are measurably less likely to end up in a formal process at all — not because their problems are smaller, but because the problem gets addressed while it is still small.

What the relationship is for

Two misconceptions get in the way. The first is that involving your People Partner escalates a situation. The opposite is true: a five-minute call about an emerging concern is the ordinary use of the function, and the situations that become formal are overwhelmingly the ones that were left alone too long. The second is that consultation is an admission that you cannot handle your team. Every experienced manager in the Company consults routinely. It is a practice, not a confession.

Concretely, your People Partner holds three things you do not have:

- **The comparator set.** They know how similar situations were handled across the Company, which is the single input you most need and most lack when calibrating a response.
- **The pattern view.** They may know that the person you are describing has raised a concern elsewhere, is in an active process, or has an accommodation you are not entitled to know about — and can steer you away from a decision you would not otherwise know was dangerous.
- **The sequencing.** Many situations have an order of operations that matters legally, and getting the order wrong cannot be undone afterwards even if every individual step was correct.

How to bring a problem

The quality of the help you get is largely determined by how you frame the ask. Managers commonly arrive with a conclusion and seek endorsement, which wastes the consultation entirely — you get validation of a decision you have already made, rather than the alternatives you needed.

Bring	Why
The facts, in date order	Dates and observable events, not your interpretation. Let them form their own read; they will spot things you have stopped seeing.
What you have already said to the person	Including anything you regret saying. They cannot protect you from a statement they do not know about, and they will find out eventually.
What you have in writing	Or the honest admission that you have nothing. This single fact changes the available options more than anything else you will say.
The two options you are torn between	Rather than the one you have chosen. This turns the conversation into a genuine consultation.
What you are worried about	Including the unflattering worry — that you have handled it badly, that you have left it too long, that you dislike the person. These are the most useful facts in the room.

Anything in the last three months

Complaints, leave, accommodation, pay conversations, absences, internal applications. Even if you are certain they are unrelated. *Especially* then.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · OPENING A CONSULTATION

"I've got a situation with one of my team that I don't think is formal yet, and I'd like to keep it that way. Can I walk you through it and get your read before I do anything?"

"I think I may have handled the last conversation badly. Can we look at where that leaves me?"

"I'm torn between two responses here and I can argue both. Can you help me work out which one is actually right rather than which one is easier?"

When to call before you do anything at all

Some situations have a first move that determines everything afterwards. In these, call before you speak to the employee, not after.

- Anyone has used the words harassment, discrimination, retaliation, unsafe, unpaid, or fraud — in any register, including jokingly.
- You are considering any negative step regarding someone who has, in the past twelve months, raised a concern, requested leave or an accommodation, discussed pay, or participated in an investigation.
- You have learned something about an employee's health, disability, pregnancy, religion or family situation, however you learned it.
- Two of your team are in conflict and one of them has framed it in terms of how they are being treated rather than what is being done.
- You are about to write anything that characterises a person rather than describes an event.
- An employee has asked to record a meeting, brought a representative, or referred to a lawyer.
- You are about to make an exception you could not defend if it became the precedent.
- You have realised something you did or approved was wrong.

JUDGMENT CALL · "THEY TOLD ME IN CONFIDENCE"

Someone tells you something serious and asks you not to repeat it. Your instinct is to honour that, both because you were trusted and because breaking it feels like a betrayal that will cost you every future disclosure.

You cannot honour it, and the way you handle the next sixty seconds determines whether you keep the relationship. Do not promise confidentiality before you know what is coming — the practised move is to say, warmly and early, *"before you go on: if it's something I'm required to pass on, I will have to, and I'd rather you knew that now than found out afterwards."* If you are already past that point, be straight: *"I'm glad you told me. I have to pass this on — that's not my choice and it's there to protect you. What I can do is tell you exactly who I'm telling and what happens next, and stay with you through it."*

People rarely resent the escalation. They resent being told afterwards, by someone else, that it happened.

Making the relationship work over time

The managers who get the most from this function do three unremarkable things. They have a standing conversation rather than only crisis calls, so that context already exists when something goes wrong. They report back on what happened after taking advice, which is rarer than it should be and makes the next conversation sharper. And they say when they disagree — a People Partner would far rather hear "I don't think that's right for this person, here's why" than watch a manager nod and then do something else.

PART TWO · BUILDING THE TEAM

4 · Hiring

The requisition process starts after the hardest thinking is supposed to have happened. This chapter is about that thinking — and about the four or five judgment calls the process hands back to you.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

Requisition approval, job description requirements, posting obligations, pay-range disclosure, prohibited questions, selection documentation, offer authority, background screening and offer rescission are all governed by Employee Handbook §§14–16, with the end-to-end procedure at SOP-HR-01 (§133). Pre-access screening and provisioning sequencing are in the Information Security Manual §2.4.1 and §8.3. None of that is repeated here.

Before the requisition: defining the role honestly

Most bad hires are decided before anyone is interviewed, at the moment a manager writes a job description describing the person they wish they could hire rather than the job that actually exists. Three questions, answered in writing, before you open anything:

What will this person have done in twelve months for us to say the hire worked?

Write three to five outcomes, in the past tense, as though the year has happened. Not responsibilities — *outcomes*. "Owns the reporting pipeline" is a responsibility and tells you nothing. "Migrated the twelve legacy jobs, reduced month-end close from nine days to four, and trained two analysts to run it without them" is an outcome set, and it tells you immediately what to interview for and what seniority the role needs.

This exercise regularly kills the requisition, which is a good result. If you cannot write three outcomes, you do not have a role; you have a feeling of being under-resourced. Those need different responses.

Is this a hire, a redesign, or a development opportunity?

If the honest answer is...	Then
"Someone on the team could do this with support"	You are looking at a development assignment plus a more junior backfill, not a lateral hire. This is usually cheaper, faster, better for retention, and harder — because it requires you to actually coach someone.
"The work only exists because of how we've organised"	Fix the organisation. Hiring into a structural problem embeds it and gives the new person an unwinnable job.
"We need this skill and nobody here has it or wants it"	A genuine hire. Proceed — and be honest in the scorecard that the skill, not the seniority, is what you are buying.
"We're drowning"	Diagnose before hiring. Volume problems are sometimes headcount problems and are more often prioritisation, tooling or scope problems. A new person will not fix a team that has not decided what it is not doing.

What is the real seniority?

Level inflation in the requisition is the most expensive quiet mistake in hiring. It happens because a higher level attracts more applicants and feels more likely to be approved. The consequences arrive later: you hire someone genuinely senior into work that will bore them within a year, or you hire someone at a level they cannot sustain and create a performance problem you manufactured yourself.

The test: of the outcomes you wrote, how many require someone to operate without direction, define the problem rather than solve it, and influence people who do not report to them? If the answer is "most," it is a senior role. If the answer is "one, occasionally," it is not, and saying so now saves everyone a difficult year.

Writing a scorecard

The job description is a compliance and attraction document. The **scorecard** is your working instrument: the four to six things you will actually assess, defined precisely enough that two different interviewers would score the same answer the same way. It sits behind the interview plan and it is the thing that makes structured interviewing produce evidence rather than opinions.

PRACTICE TOOL · SCORECARD ANATOMY

For each competency, write three things:

1. **The behavioural definition.** What does this look like in the work? Not "collaboration" but "surfaces disagreement with peers directly and early rather than escalating or acquiescing."
2. **The evidence that would satisfy you.** A specific example type: "has changed their own position after a peer challenged it, and can describe what changed their mind."
3. **The anchors.** What a weak, adequate and strong answer sounds like. Two sentences each. This is the part people skip and it is the part that produces consistency.

Four to six competencies maximum. A scorecard with eleven lines is a wish list, and interviewers silently collapse it back to a general impression — which is exactly what the scorecard exists to prevent.

Anchors: a worked example

Competency	Weak	Adequate	Strong
Handling ambiguity	Describes waiting for direction; frames ambiguity as someone else's failure to specify; the example resolves because someone else decided.	Describes making a reasonable call and proceeding; can explain the choice; limited evidence of testing the assumption or revisiting it.	Describes narrowing the ambiguity deliberately — what they did to reduce it cheaply before committing, what they decided to leave unresolved, and how they knew if they were wrong.

Written this way, "handling ambiguity" stops being a vibe. Two interviewers hearing the same story will now largely agree, and — crucially — an interviewer who scores a candidate low has to point at the absence of a specific thing rather than at a feeling.

FAILURE MODE · THE UNWRITTEN COMPETENCY

Every panel has one: the criterion nobody put on the scorecard but everyone is quietly assessing. Usually it is some version of "would I enjoy working with this person," which is a legitimate thing to care about and an illegitimate thing to assess unnamed — because unnamed, it tracks similarity to the interviewer with striking reliability.

If it matters, name it and define it behaviourally. "Works well with this team" becomes "gives and receives direct feedback without escalation," which is assessable, defensible, and not a proxy for background. If you cannot write a behavioural definition, that is your answer about whether it belongs in the decision.

Deciding what you will trade

Every real candidate is a bundle of strengths and gaps, and the decision is never "is this person good." It is "which gap am I willing to own." Decide this *before* you meet anyone, because after you meet a compelling candidate you will rationalise whichever gap they happen to have.

Write down, in advance: the one competency where you will not compromise; the one where you will accept adequate and develop; and the one you are prepared to cover from elsewhere on the team. Then, when the panel is split, you have a prior rather than a preference.

Sourcing: what a hiring manager actually contributes

Talent Acquisition owns the channels. What only you can contribute is threefold, and managers who do these three things fill roles substantially faster:

- **Name twenty people.** Not to poach — to describe the population. "Who are the twenty people whose work I admire in this space, and where do they gather, publish, or come from?" This single exercise redirects a search more usefully than any brief.
- **Widen the pool at the requirement stage, not the shortlist stage.** Every unnecessary requirement — a degree where experience is equivalent, a years-of-experience floor, a specific tool where the underlying skill transfers, "must have worked at scale" without defining scale — removes candidates invisibly and disproportionately. Diversity of shortlist is decided in the job description, not by the recruiter.
- **Respond within a day.** Strong candidates are in three processes. The manager's turnaround on feedback and scheduling is the variable most within your control and the one that most often loses you the hire.

Deciding when the panel splits

A split panel is normal and is not a problem to be resolved by voting. It is information about where the risk sits. Work it in this order:

1. **Locate the disagreement on the scorecard.** Are people scoring the same competency differently, or weighing different competencies? These are entirely different situations. The first is an evidence dispute and is resolvable — go back to what the candidate actually said. The second is a role-definition dispute, which means the scorecard was wrong and you need to settle the trade-off explicitly.
2. **Ask the dissenter to state the specific evidence, not the conclusion.** "I wasn't convinced" is not usable. "When I asked about the failed migration, they described what the team did but couldn't tell me what they would do differently" is usable and can be tested with a follow-up conversation.

3. **Weight the interviewer closest to the work.** Not the most senior person in the room. The person who will work alongside this candidate daily has the most calibrated read on whether the gap is survivable.
4. **Distinguish "not convinced" from "convinced not."** The first is a gap in your evidence and is often fixable with one more targeted conversation or a work sample. The second is a decision. Panels routinely treat the first as the second and lose good candidates through incomplete process rather than genuine concern.
5. **If still split, do not average.** A candidate that half your panel does not want, hired anyway, starts with an information deficit they never learn about and a set of colleagues quietly waiting to be proved right.

JUDGMENT CALL · THE STRONG CANDIDATE WITH ONE BAD INTERVIEW

Three interviewers are enthusiastic, one is firmly negative. Do you discount the outlier?

Investigate before you discount. Two questions decide it. *What was that interviewer assessing?* If they were the only person probing the competency you said you would not compromise on, they are not an outlier — they are the only person who tested the thing that matters, and the other three assessed something easier. *What happened in the room?* Interviews go badly for reasons unrelated to the candidate: a hostile framing, a technical failure, a scheduling disaster, an interviewer having a bad day. Ask.

What you must not do is discount the dissent because it is inconvenient and the process has taken eleven weeks. Sunk cost is the most reliable predictor of a bad hire, and the negative interviewer will remember that you overrode them.

Closing a candidate without over-promising

Talent Acquisition extends the offer. What you do is the part that decides whether it is accepted — and the part where managers most often create a problem for their future selves.

The pressure is real: you are near the end of a long search, the candidate has another offer, and the sentence that would close them is right there. It is almost always a sentence about the future — the promotion, the scope, the team you will build, the certainty that they will love it. Those sentences are remembered verbatim, repeated to colleagues, and produce a disillusioned employee in month nine when the future turns out to be contingent on things you did not control.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · CLOSING ON WHAT IS TRUE

Instead of "You'd be in line for a senior role within eighteen months" —

"Here's what I can tell you honestly. The work in front of you for the next year is X and Y. The people who've grown fastest on this team did it by doing Z. I can't promise a timeline on a promotion and I won't, but I can tell you what the path looks like and that I'll be actively working it with you."

Instead of "It's a great culture, you'll love it" —

"Two things I'd want to know if I were you. The thing people like most about this team is that decisions get made in writing and you don't have to be in the room to matter. The thing people find hardest is that we run lean, so you'll be more on your own than you might be somewhere bigger. If that second one is a problem, better to know now."

Naming a genuine downside is the most persuasive thing you can do. It makes everything else you have said credible, and it filters out the people for whom it would not have worked.

FAILURE MODE · THE INFORMAL OFFER

You are excited, the conversation is going well, and you say "we'd love to have you — I'm thinking somewhere around the top of the band." You have now anchored a number you do not control, in a conversation you are not authorised to have, and whatever the written offer says will feel like a reduction.

Everything about numbers, dates, level and terms goes through Talent Acquisition. Your job in the closing conversation is the work, the team and the honest picture. *"I'm not the right person to talk numbers — that's a conversation with the recruiter and they'll come to you with something concrete. What I can talk about is the job."*

The first ninety days are part of the hire

A hire is not complete at acceptance; it is complete when the person is productive and has decided to stay. The onboarding sequence and its owners are specified at SOP-HR-02, which you should follow. What the SOP cannot specify is the judgment part:

- **Decide what "good at 30, 60, 90" means before day one**, and tell them on day one. New joiners overwhelmingly report that the hardest part is not knowing whether they are doing well. You can remove that entirely in one conversation.
- **Give them something real in week two**. Not a reading list. A small, genuine, finishable piece of work whose completion they can point at. Confidence in a new role is built by shipping, not by absorbing.
- **Protect them from your own urgency**. The temptation is to hand a new senior hire the problem you have been drowning in. They do not yet know enough about the context to succeed at it, and failing at their first visible task is very hard to recover from.
- **Ask at week six what surprised them**. This is the only moment you will ever get an outsider's clear view of your own team, and it expires. Write down what they say.

PART TWO · BUILDING THE TEAM

5 · Interviewing

Structured interviewing is required. Doing it well is a separate skill, and it is mostly about the questions you ask second.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

The requirement for a defined interview plan, common core questions, interviewer certification, written feedback before the debrief, panel composition, prohibited topics and the pay-range disclosure sequence are set out in Employee Handbook §14.4–§14.7. Interviewer certification cadence is in §69.3. This chapter assumes all of that and addresses technique only.

Writing questions that produce evidence

A well-formed interview question makes it easy for a strong candidate to demonstrate something and hard for a weak one to bluff. Most questions fail on the second half.

Question type	What it actually measures
Hypothetical "What would you do if..."	How well the candidate reasons about your problem in the abstract, and how quickly they can construct a plausible answer. Weakly correlated with what they have ever done. Useful only as a supplement.
Self-assessment "Are you good at..."	Confidence and cultural norms about self-promotion. Essentially nothing else. These questions systematically disadvantage candidates from backgrounds where self-promotion is discouraged.
Behavioural "Tell me about a time when..."	What they have actually done — <i>if</i> you follow up. Unprobed, a behavioural question measures rehearsal quality, because every candidate has three polished stories.
Behavioural + probe "...and what did you try first?"	The real target. Rehearsed answers are smooth at the summary level and thin two layers down. Genuine experience gets richer the deeper you go.
Work sample "Here is a real artefact..."	The best available predictor for most roles. Also the most demanding to design and the fairest to candidates who interview badly but work well.

Ask for the specific instance, not the general practice

"How do you handle disagreement with a peer?" invites a philosophy. "Tell me about the last time you disagreed with a peer and it did not get resolved quickly" invites a fact. The word *last* is doing a great deal of work: it prevents the candidate from selecting their best example and gets you a representative one.

The probing ladder

This is the core interviewing skill and it is almost entirely about the second, third and fourth questions. After any behavioural answer, descend:

PRACTICE TOOL · FOUR RUNGS DOWN

1. **Scope.** "What was your specific part of that, as distinct from the team's?" — Separates contribution from proximity. Listen for the pronoun shift from "we" to "I" and back.
2. **Sequence.** "What did you try first, and what happened?" — Real work is iterative and has a false start. Answers with no false start are usually summaries of something someone else did.
3. **Alternatives.** "What else did you consider and why did you rule it out?" — Distinguishes a decision from a default. Someone who genuinely made the call can name the road not taken.
4. **Reflection.** "What would you do differently?" — The strongest signal in the interview. Weak candidates say "nothing" or blame a constraint. Strong candidates have a specific, unflattering, technical answer they have clearly thought about since.

Two full ladders in an hour beat eight unprobed questions. Plan for depth and cut your question list accordingly.

Handling the answer that is too smooth

When an answer arrives fully formed and perfectly structured, do not be impressed and do not be suspicious. Just go somewhere the preparation did not reach: ask about the part that went wrong, ask who disagreed with them, ask what the person on the other side of it would say about the same events. Preparation covers achievements. It rarely covers friction.

Taking notes you can defend

Write down what the candidate *said*, in their words, close to verbatim for the parts that matter. Do not write your reaction. There are two reasons, and both are practical.

First, in the debrief, quoted evidence beats remembered impression every time and is the only thing that resolves disagreement. Second, your notes may be read later in a discrimination claim or an audit, and the difference between *"said the team missed the deadline; when asked what he'd changed, said 'nothing, the requirements were bad'"* and *"defensive, blamed others, poor attitude"* is the difference between a defensible record and an exhibit.

A useful discipline: your notes should contain more quotation marks than adjectives.

Running a debrief that is not a popularity contest

Written feedback is submitted before the debrief precisely so that the room does not converge on the first confident opinion. Preserve that. As the hiring manager chairing the session:

1. **Do not speak first and do not signal.** If you open with your view, you will hear it back from at least two people. Go around the room in reverse seniority.
2. **Go competency by competency, not interviewer by interviewer.** "What did we learn about how this person handles ambiguity?" pulls evidence from four interviews into one place. "Sam, what did you think?" produces four holistic verdicts and a vote.
3. **Demand the evidence behind every score.** Every time someone offers a conclusion, ask what the candidate said that produced it. Do this consistently and neutrally, including for positive scores — the enthusiastic verdict deserves the same scrutiny as the negative one.

4. **Name the gaps in the evidence.** "Nobody actually tested whether they can run a project without a project manager" is a legitimate and common finding. The response is another conversation, not a guess.
5. **Interrupt similarity language.** "Reminds me of X," "one of us," "would fit right in," "not quite our kind of engineer" — these are not assessments and they need to be named as out of scope in the moment, by you, every time. This is the single highest-value thing a chair does.

FAILURE MODE · THE CONFIDENCE-COMPETENCE SWAP

Interview performance rewards fluency, comfort with strangers, and the cultural habit of claiming credit. None of these is on your scorecard. The systematic result is that panels over-select for people who interview like the panel and under-select for people who are quieter, more precise, non-native speakers, or from backgrounds where individual credit claiming is discouraged — and then describe the outcome as "chemistry."

Counter it mechanically rather than by good intentions: score against written anchors, require quoted evidence, weight work samples, and treat "presence," "polish," "energy" and "gravitas" as unscorable unless someone can convert them into an observable behaviour the job actually requires.

Assessing potential without assessing yourself

For roles where the candidate will grow into the job, you are assessing trajectory rather than current state. This is legitimate and it is where bias concentrates, because "potential" is the most projectable of all judgments.

Make it evidential. Potential shows up as a *rate*, and rates are observable: what did this person not know eighteen months ago that they know now? What did they teach themselves and how do they know they learned it? What feedback have they received that changed their behaviour, and what changed? A candidate with a demonstrable learning rate has evidence of potential. A candidate who reminds you of yourself has not.

Work samples and remote interviewing

Designing a work sample that is fair

- **Cap the time and mean it.** Ninety minutes, stated, with an explicit instruction to stop. Uncapped exercises select for candidates without caring responsibilities or second jobs.
- **Use a real, declassified problem.** Candidates can tell the difference, and a genuine problem produces a genuine conversation. Never use live work you would otherwise pay for.
- **Score with anchors written before you see any submission.** Otherwise the first submission becomes the standard.
- **Debrief it with them.** The conversation about their choices is worth more than the artefact. It also lets a candidate who misread the brief recover, which is a fairness point.

Remote interviews

Most interviewing is now video, which changes the mechanics more than people allow for.

- Turnover is harder to read and silence feels longer. Deliberately wait two extra beats after asking a question; the best answers arrive after a pause and video pressure suppresses them.

- Say at the start that you will be taking notes and looking away. Otherwise candidates read note-taking as disengagement and adjust their answers to recover you.
- Do not penalise the environment. Background, connection quality, interruptions, and whether someone has a study or a kitchen table are socio-economic signals, not job signals.
- Build in the part that would have happened in the corridor: five minutes at the end for their questions, and an honest answer to the one they actually care about. Remote candidates get much less unstructured information about you and decide on less.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · OPENING AN INTERVIEW SO THE CANDIDATE CAN PERFORM

"Before we start — here's the shape of the next 45 minutes. I'll ask you about three specific things you've worked on and I'll dig into them fairly deeply, so if I keep asking follow-ups it's not because something's wrong, it's how I get past the summary. I'll leave ten minutes at the end for your questions. And I'll be typing while you talk — I'm taking notes, not multitasking."

Thirty seconds. It measurably improves the quality of what you get, particularly from nervous candidates, and it costs you nothing. An interview is not a test of composure under ambiguity unless the job is.

PART THREE · GROWING THE TEAM

6 · Coaching

Coaching is the part of the job with the least policy attached and the largest effect. It is also the first thing to disappear when you are busy, which is why teams with good managers and teams with overloaded managers diverge so sharply over two years.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

The 1:1 cadence requirement, the feedback structure, upward and peer feedback mechanics, development plan expectations and the career framework are in Employee Handbook §64 and §69. This chapter is about what happens inside those meetings.

The four-cause diagnostic

Before coaching anyone on anything, work out which of four things you are looking at. Applying the wrong one is worse than doing nothing: coaching a clarity problem as a skill problem tells a capable person they are inadequate, and coaching an environment problem as a will problem is how you lose someone good.

Cause	The signature	What actually helps
Clarity	They are working hard on the wrong thing, or their definition of finished differs from yours. Often they are surprised by your dissatisfaction. Frequently the manager has explained it once, early, in a meeting.	Not coaching. Specification. Write down the outcome, the standard, the constraints and who decides. Ask them to play it back in their own words — this is where you discover the gap, every time.
Skill	They know what good looks like and cannot yet produce it. Usually they know, and are quietly embarrassed. Effort is present; output is not.	Deliberate practice on the specific sub-skill, plus a model to copy and fast feedback loops. Break the work down smaller than feels necessary. Timebox it: "let's look at this again in three weeks."
Will	They can do it and are not. Careful here — genuine will problems are much rarer than managers believe, and the label is where frustration goes to hide.	A direct conversation about what has changed. Nearly always there is a cause: a broken promise, a promotion that did not come, a role that outgrew them, something outside work. Find it before you respond to the symptom.
Environment	A capable, motivated person is being defeated by the system — a dependency, a tool, a broken interface with another team, an overloaded queue, a colleague. Often visible in the fact that others in the same seat also struggle.	Your job, not theirs. Coaching someone to be more resilient inside a broken system is the most demoralising thing a manager can do, and they will remember it.

PRACTICE TOOL · THE DIAGNOSTIC QUESTION

One question separates all four, asked neutrally and early:

"If you had to make this go well, with no constraints on you at all — what would need to be different?"

Clarity problems produce "I'd want to know what you actually mean by X." Skill problems produce "I'd want to have done this before / I'd want someone to show me." Will problems produce a long silence or something about a different subject entirely. Environment problems produce an immediate, specific, and usually accurate complaint about something structural.

What a good 1:1 is for

The most common failure of the 1:1 is that it becomes a status update, which is a meeting the manager needs and the employee does not. Status can be written. The 1:1 is the employee's meeting and its purpose is the things that do not survive being written down: the thing they are avoiding, the decision they are stuck on, the conflict they have not named, the ambition they have not said out loud.

Structure without rigidity

- **They set the agenda**, in a shared running document, before the meeting. If they arrive with nothing, that is data — usually about how safe the meeting feels, not about how little there is.
- **Your items go at the end**. Whatever is at the top consumes the time, and if that is your list you have converted their meeting into yours.
- **Leave the last five minutes for the harder thing**. The most important item of a 1:1 has a strong tendency to arrive at minute 27 of 30. Do not schedule something immediately afterwards.
- **Never cancel; reschedule**. A cancelled 1:1 says the meeting is what you do with spare time. Two in a row says it louder. If you must move it, move it in the same message.

Questions that get past "fine"

- "What's taking more of your energy than it should?"
- "What have you been putting off?"
- "Where are you waiting on someone?"
- "What would you do differently if it were entirely your call?"
- "What did I get wrong this week?" — asked seriously and repeatedly, this eventually produces real answers.
- "Is there anything you've decided not to tell me?" — used sparingly. It works.

Delegation as a development instrument

Most development happens through work, and delegation is the mechanism. Managers routinely delegate at one setting — usually "do this and tell me when it's done" — and then wonder why people are not growing. The setting is the tool.

Level

Use it when

1 · Do exactly this	High stakes, low experience, or genuine urgency. Honest and appropriate; just do not live here.
2 · Look into it, bring me options	Building analytical judgment. You still decide, and you tell them which option you chose and why — that last part is the development, and it is the part that gets skipped.
3 · Recommend, then act unless I object	The workhorse level for growing people. They own the thinking; you retain a veto you should use rarely and explain every time you do.
4 · Decide and tell me	They own it. Your role is context and air cover. Resist reopening decisions you would have made differently but that were reasonable.
5 · Own it entirely	You find out through the ordinary reporting. This is what "senior" actually means and people cannot demonstrate readiness for it until you allow it.

Say the level out loud. Nearly all delegation friction — the person who over-consults, the person who surprises you, the manager who feels undermined — is an unstated mismatch about which level was in play. Nine words prevents it: *"You own this one; tell me if you need air cover."*

FAILURE MODE · TAKING IT BACK

You delegate at level 4. It starts going in a direction you would not have chosen. You step in, "just to help," and make the call yourself.

You have taught two lessons: that delegation here is provisional, and that the way to avoid being overridden is to check with you constantly. You will now get more of exactly the behaviour you were trying to grow out of. If the decision is genuinely too important to let go, delegate at level 3 in the first place. If you delegated at 4 and are uncomfortable, coach the reasoning — *"walk me through how you got there"* — and let a survivable wrong decision happen. Recoverable failure is the entire mechanism by which people become senior.

Coaching your strongest performers

High performers get the least coaching, because nothing is on fire and their 1:1s are pleasant. Then they leave, and the exit interview says they were not growing.

Three things they need that a struggling colleague does not:

- **A harder problem, before they ask.** The reliable signal of an under-stretched strong performer is that they have started optimising things nobody asked them to optimise. That is capacity looking for somewhere to go.
- **Feedback at their level, not relief that things are fine.** Excellent people are usually under-coached because their work clears the bar easily and their manager has nothing to say. Raise the bar: what would make this exceptional rather than very good? What is the next-level version of this? They can take it, and they are starved of it.
- **Honesty about the ceiling.** If the next role does not exist here, say so early. People forgive a constrained organisation. They do not forgive discovering at month thirty that you knew at month six.

Coaching people you cannot out-expert

At some point you will manage someone better than you at the thing they do. Managers handle this badly in two directions: pretending to a technical authority they do not have, which is immediately transparent, or withdrawing entirely, which abandons the person.

Neither is necessary, because the thing you can see and they cannot is not the craft — it is everything around it. Say it plainly and coach that.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · MANAGING A DEEPER EXPERT

"You know this area better than I do and I'm not going to pretend otherwise — I'm not going to second-guess your technical calls. What I can see that you can't is how this lands elsewhere, where the organisational resistance is, and what it looks like from outside your team. That's what I'll be useful for. And I'll ask you naive questions sometimes — that's me checking my own understanding, not challenging yours."

What you coach: influence without authority, how their work is perceived, decision communication, what the next level of scope requires, the political landscape, when to escalate and when to absorb, and how to develop the people around them. That is a full agenda and none of it requires you to be the better engineer.

PART THREE · GROWING THE TEAM

7 · Performance Reviews

The review is not a document-writing exercise in December. It is a year-long evidence-gathering exercise with a conversation at the end, and managers who treat it as the former produce reviews that are recency-biased, unfair and indefensible.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

The cycle calendar, rating scale and definitions, the no-forced-distribution rule, calibration requirements, fair assessment obligations, review conversation requirements, the disagreement route, and the improvement plan framework are all in Employee Handbook §§61–65. Nothing in this chapter changes any of it.

The evidence file

Everything else in this chapter depends on this one habit, and it is the habit most managers do not have.

Keep a running note per person. Add to it when something happens, not when you need it. Three or four entries a month is sufficient. Each entry is one or two lines: *date — what happened — what it demonstrated*. Both directions; the file that only records problems is worse than useless, because it produces a review that reads like a prosecution and a manager who cannot remember a single specific success.

PRACTICE TOOL · WHAT AN EVIDENCE FILE LOOKS LIKE

14 Feb — Caught the reconciliation error before it reached the customer. Nobody asked her to check. Scope of ownership beyond the assignment.

3 Mar — Ran the incident review. Kept it factual, no blame, produced three actions that actually got done. Two engineers told me separately it was the best one they'd been in.

19 Mar — Second missed commitment on the migration doc. Told me the day it was due, not before. Raised in 1:1 same week; agreed she'd flag slippage at the halfway point.

28 Apr — Flagged the pipeline slip at halfway, as agreed. Change stuck.

11 Jun — Pushed back on my sequencing in the planning meeting, in front of the team, with a better argument. I was wrong. Worth saying so in the review.

Five entries, four months, under two minutes of work each. In December this produces a specific, balanced, dated, defensible review — and, more valuably, a review with nothing in it the employee has not already heard.

Three uses beyond the review itself. It kills recency bias, which is the largest single distortion in ratings. It makes calibration winnable, because you arrive with dates and everyone else arrives with impressions. And it converts a vague worry into a specific concern early enough to fix, which is how performance problems get solved rather than documented.

From evidence to rating

The move from a year of evidence to a single word is where managers go wrong in predictable ways. Four disciplines:

- **Rate the year, weighted by consequence — not by recency and not by volume.** One decision in March that changed the team's trajectory may outweigh eight months of steady delivery. Say so explicitly rather than averaging.
- **Rate against the level, not against the team.** The question is whether this person met the expectations of *their* level. Not whether they were the best of your five. A team of strong people can contain several who exceeded the level; a team of five can contain none.
- **Separate results from conditions.** Someone whose project was cancelled for reasons outside their control has not underperformed. Someone whose project succeeded because market conditions changed has not outperformed. Assess the contribution.
- **Write the sentence before you pick the word.** Draft the two or three pieces of evidence that drive the rating, then see which rating those sentences actually support. Managers who choose the rating first and assemble the justification afterwards produce reviews that read as constructed, because they are.

FAILURE MODE · THE RATING YOU GAVE TO AVOID A CONVERSATION

You know the honest rating is "partially achieves." You give "achieves," because the conversation is unpleasant, the person is nice, and it is only one notch.

Four consequences, all of which land on you later. The employee is denied the information they needed to correct course, and will be blindsided if it ever comes to a formal process. Your other team members, who can see the difference in output, learn that the rating is unrelated to the work. The record you have created makes any future action look retaliatory or arbitrary — an "achieves" in January and a warning in April is very difficult to defend. And you have deferred the same conversation to a version of yourself with less room to manoeuvre.

Writing the narrative

A good review is short, specific, dated and unsurprising. Structure that reliably works:

1. **The headline judgment, in one sentence.** Not buried. Not preceded by four paragraphs of throat-clearing.
2. **Two or three pieces of evidence that drive it.** With dates and outcomes. This is the whole document, really.
3. **The most important area to develop, stated once and specifically.** One thing. A list of five development areas is a list of zero, because nobody can work on five.
4. **What you will do about it.** Reviews that assign development entirely to the employee are half a document.

Three sentence-level habits

Instead of

Write

"Sometimes struggles with stakeholder communication."	"On the Q2 launch, the finance team learned about the scope change from the release note rather than from you. When you pre-briefed them ahead of the Q3 change, the approval took two days instead of three weeks."
"Needs to show more leadership."	"The next level requires setting direction others follow when you are not in the room. The clearest opportunity is the reporting standard — nobody owns it, you have the strongest view, and if you wrote it people would use it."
"Great year, keep it up."	"Two things stood out: the incident review process you built is now used by three other teams, and you flagged the pipeline risk early enough that we could act. The second one is rarer than the first and I want to see more of it."

The pattern: replace the adverb of frequency with an instance, replace the abstraction with a behaviour, and replace the compliment with the reason it mattered.

Preparing to defend a rating in calibration

Calibration exists to align standards, and it works only if managers arrive with evidence rather than advocacy. Prepare three things for each person you expect to be discussed:

- **The two-sentence case.** If you cannot state the rating and its basis in two sentences, you do not have a case yet — you have a feeling and some paperwork.
- **The comparator.** Who else at this level did comparable work, and how do the two compare on the evidence? This is the actual question calibration asks and the one managers are least ready for.
- **The counter-case.** The strongest argument against your own rating, prepared in advance. Managers who have done this are visibly more credible, and it stops you defending a position you would not have chosen if someone else had proposed it.

Two things to expect and handle well. If your ratings are noticeably more generous or more severe than your peers', you will be asked to explain — in either direction, and this is legitimate. And if someone challenges a rating with evidence you did not have, change it. A manager who never moves in calibration is not calibrating; they are negotiating.

FAILURE MODE · TRADING

"I'll come down on Priya if you'll come up on Tom." This is the corruption of calibration and it happens quietly, usually framed as reasonableness. It produces ratings unrelated to evidence, it disadvantages whoever's manager advocates least aggressively, and every participant in the room now knows the system is not real.

If you see it, name it — "*can we go back to what the evidence supports for each of them separately?*" If you cannot name it in the room, raise it with the People Partner afterwards. They attend for exactly this reason.

Delivering the review

The conversation requirements are in policy. The craft is in three places.

Before. Send nothing that lets them read the rating alone in advance without you. Book enough time that neither of you is watching a clock. Decide the one thing you most want them to remember in six months, and build around it — people retain approximately one thing from a review.

During. Rating early, evidence next, then stop talking. The instinct after delivering a difficult message is to keep filling the silence, and it is exactly wrong: it dilutes the message, it reads as discomfort, and it denies the person the moment they need to react. Ask what their reaction is and then actually wait.

After. The week following is the part everyone forgets. Whatever the rating, check in within seven days — reviews land slowly and the real reaction usually arrives two days later, when they have re-read it. For a difficult review, this check-in is the difference between a person who recalibrates and a person who starts looking.

The five reactions and what each needs

Reaction	What is happening	What to do
Silence	Processing, or a decision to disengage from the conversation. You cannot tell which yet, and filling the gap guarantees you never find out.	Wait. Genuinely wait — count to ten. Then: "I've given you a lot. Take the week. Let's talk again Thursday when you've sat with it."
Tears	Almost never about the rating alone. Usually accumulated, and frequently there is something else going on.	Stop, offer a break, do not comfort your way out of the message. "Take a minute. There's no rush and we can pick this up later if you'd rather." Do not retract anything to make it stop.
Anger	Usually surprise wearing a different coat. If they are angry, ask yourself first whether this genuinely is the first they have heard of it — if so, that is your failure and you should say so.	Do not match it and do not retreat. "I can see this has landed badly. Tell me what you think I've got wrong." Then listen to the content, not the delivery.
Bargaining	They want the rating changed, and they are testing whether it is negotiable.	Be unambiguous that the rating reflects the evidence and is not a negotiation, and equally unambiguous about the route if they believe the process was flawed. Then redirect to what changes next cycle.
Agreement, too fast	The most concerning of the five. "Yeah, totally fair, I know" often means they have stopped listening, or they are managing you.	Slow it down. "Tell me what you think the main thing is, in your own words." If they cannot, they did not hear it and you will be having this conversation again in June.

PART THREE · GROWING THE TEAM

8 · Promotions

Promotion decisions produce more lasting resentment than any other people process, almost entirely because of how they are communicated rather than how they are decided.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

Eligibility, the internal application process, the requirement for demonstrated sustained performance at the next level, calibration, compensation placement, lateral moves, acting differentials and relocation are all governed by Employee Handbook §22, with the prohibition on promises at §14.8 and §129.2. This chapter covers assessment craft and the conversations.

The readiness evidence test

The standard is sustained performance *at the next level* — not excellence at the current one, and not tenure. That distinction is easy to state and hard to apply, because a manager's sense that someone is ready is usually built from an accumulation of good work rather than from evidence of a different kind of work.

Four tests. A genuinely ready candidate passes all four, and you should be able to produce a named instance for each.

Test	What you are looking for
The scope test	They have already operated at the next level's scope on at least one substantial piece of work — not once by accident, but with a result you can point to. "Would grow into it" is a prediction. Promotion committees decide on evidence.
The absence test	When you are away, do they hold the ground? The next level is largely defined by operating without direction. This is why holiday cover is the most informative development assignment you have.
The peer test	Do people at the target level already treat them as one of them — bring them problems, cite them, seek their view? Peer recognition at the target level is the least gameable signal available and it is visible if you look.
The hardest-part test	Every level has one thing that is genuinely harder than the level below. Name it for this role — usually it is deciding without enough information, or being accountable for others' output, or holding a position under pressure. Have they done <i>that</i> yet, specifically?

FAILURE MODE · PROMOTING THE PERSON WHO IS DOING THE JOB ALREADY, ONLY LATER

Two people. One has quietly been operating at the next level for a year; nobody has noticed because they do not raise it. The other asks every quarter, is visible, and is a solid performer at their current level.

The asker gets promoted more often. Not through favouritism — through availability. They are in your mind when the slot opens. This is one of the main mechanisms by which promotion outcomes diverge along lines of confidence, gender and background, and the fix is mechanical rather than attitudinal: **before each cycle, list every person on your team and apply the four tests to each, in writing, whether or not they have asked.** Twenty minutes. It reliably surfaces someone.

Judgment: promoting into management

The most consequential promotion you will make, and the one most often made for the wrong reason. Being the best individual contributor is close to uncorrelated with being a good manager, and promoting on that basis costs you your best practitioner and gives the team a manager who does not want the job.

Three signals worth more than technical excellence: they already take satisfaction in other people's success rather than tolerating it; they have shown willingness to have an uncomfortable conversation rather than routing around it; and they can let a piece of work be done adequately by someone else rather than doing it well themselves. The third is the hardest and the most predictive.

And ask them properly. "Do you want to manage?" gets a yes, because declining feels like declining ambition. Better: *"The management version of this role means you'd spend most of your week on other people's work and much less on your own. Some people find that a relief and some find it a loss. Which do you think you'd be?"*

Building the promotion case

A promotion case is an evidence document, not an advocacy document. Panels discount advocacy heavily and correctly. Structure:

1. **The claim.** One sentence: this person has been operating at level N+1 since roughly [date].
2. **Three instances.** Each one dated, each one describing scope and outcome, each one clearly at the target level. Not eight instances; three strong ones beat eight adequate ones, and a long list reads as compensation.
3. **The hardest-part evidence.** Specifically the thing that distinguishes the levels. Panels probe here first.
4. **External corroboration.** What peers at the target level, partner teams or customers say. One concrete quote is worth a paragraph of your own assessment.
5. **The honest gap.** Every case has one. Naming it, with what you are doing about it, makes the rest credible. A case with no weaknesses is read as a case that has not been examined.

PRACTICE TOOL · THE TWELVE-MONTH LEAD

The best time to start a promotion case is roughly a year before you submit it, and the mechanism is assignment rather than paperwork. Work backwards: what would the three instances need to be? Which of those can you create deliberately in the next four months? Who needs to see this person work in order to corroborate later?

This is the substantive difference between managers whose people get promoted and managers whose people do not. It is not advocacy skill. It is having engineered the evidence a year earlier.

The "not this cycle" conversation

Handled badly, this conversation loses people who would have stayed. Handled well, it frequently increases commitment — because it is the first time someone has told them precisely what the gap is.

Five rules:

- **Tell them yourself, promptly, before they hear the outcome elsewhere.** Finding out from a colleague's announcement is the injury people actually remember.
- **Give the real reason.** Not "it was competitive." Not "the committee decided." If the gap is the hardest-part test, say which part. Vague reasons are heard as either bias or a decision that was never really about them.
- **Do not blame the process.** "I fought for you but they wouldn't have it" feels kind and is corrosive: it tells them their manager has no influence, that the system is arbitrary, and that there is nothing they can do.
- **Be concrete about the gap and the path.** What specifically would need to be true, what work would demonstrate it, and when the next realistic decision point is. If the honest answer is that no such path exists here, say that too — early enough for them to make their own decision.
- **Never promise the next cycle.** You do not control it, and a promise you cannot keep converts one disappointment into a breach of trust.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · NOT THIS CYCLE

"I want to tell you before you hear it anywhere else: the promotion didn't go through this cycle. I'm going to tell you exactly why, because I don't think 'it was competitive' would be useful to you.

The case was strong on delivery — nobody questioned that. Where it fell down was that at the next level you're accountable for outcomes you don't personally produce, and I couldn't point to a clear instance of you doing that. That's partly on me; I haven't put you in that position.

Here's what I'd like to change in the next six months. [Specific assignment.] That's the evidence the case needs. I can't promise you an outcome next cycle and I'm not going to. What I can tell you is that this is the gap, it's a closeable one, and I'd rather be straight with you than comfortable."

The month after

Retention risk after a declined promotion peaks at four to eight weeks, not immediately. The person absorbs it, concludes nothing has changed, and starts looking. Three things materially reduce this and cost you nothing.

Change something visible within a month. The assignment you named must actually appear. Nothing confirms a fear of stagnation faster than a development conversation followed by an identical quarter.

Come back to it unprompted. Around week four: *"I've been thinking about our conversation. How are you sitting with it?"* They will not raise it themselves and they are certainly still thinking about it.

Watch for the second-order damage. If a peer was promoted, the working relationship between them may now be quietly difficult. Left alone this becomes a team problem that nobody attributes to its actual cause.

PART FOUR · HARD GROUND

9 · Difficult Conversations

Every hard conversation has the same architecture. Learn the architecture once and you can hold a conversation you have never had before, which is the actual requirement of the job.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

Employee Handbook §132 sets out the required approach for eight specific situations that carry legal or escalation obligations — including a report of harassment, a disclosure of a health condition, a question about another person's pay, a dispute about a rating, evident distress, and the delivery of a termination. Those are obligations, they are not optional, and they are not restated here. This chapter is the general craft, and the eight situations at §8.5 below are deliberately different ones.

Why they go wrong

Difficult conversations rarely fail on content. They fail on one of four things, in roughly this order of frequency:

- **They happen too late.** By the time it is said, the person has been failing for months without knowing, the manager is frustrated rather than concerned, and the message arrives with an accumulated charge that makes it sound like an accusation. Nearly every difficult conversation would have been an easy one three months earlier.
- **The message is buried.** Softened, hedged, sandwiched between praise, and delivered so gently that the person leaves the room thinking it went well. The manager believes it has been said. It has not.
- **The manager is managing their own discomfort.** Over-explaining, apologising, filling silence, retreating when the other person reacts. All of this is the manager soothing themselves, and the person notices.
- **There is no next step.** A conversation that ends with mutual acknowledgement and nothing specific changes nothing at all.

The anatomy of the conversation

Preparation — ten minutes, always

Write down four things. Not in your head; on paper, because the act of writing exposes the ones you have not actually thought through.

1. **The one sentence.** If they remember nothing else, what is the sentence? If you cannot write it, you are not ready — and if it takes three sentences, you have two conversations, not one.
2. **The evidence.** Two or three specific, dated instances. Not a pattern claim without instances; that is where the conversation collapses when challenged.
3. **The outcome you want.** Not "for them to understand." Something observable: an agreed change, a decision, a commitment, a date.
4. **The reaction you are most afraid of,** and your response to it. Usually just naming this defuses it.

The opening sentence

The most important sentence in the conversation, because it sets whether the next twenty minutes are a discussion or a defence. A good opening does three things in about fifteen words: it signals that this is a serious conversation, it names the subject, and it does not begin the argument.

Weak opening	Why it fails
"How are things? ... Good. So, anyway, I wanted to mention..."	The false-casual opening. They now know something is wrong and have spent the small talk bracing. Worse, it teaches them to distrust the next friendly opening.
"I don't want you to take this the wrong way, but..."	Pre-emptive defence. Signals that you expect a bad reaction, which reliably produces one.
"You've been doing great, really — one small thing..."	The sandwich. The praise is discounted as setup, the message is discounted as small, and you have devalued your future compliments.
"Some people have mentioned that..."	Anonymous, unownable, and unanswerable. If you have a concern, own it. If it is a report you cannot attribute, you have an escalation obligation, not a conversation.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · OPENINGS THAT WORK

"I want to talk about something that's been on my mind and I'd rather say it directly than let it sit. It's about how the Henderson handover went."

"There's something I need to raise with you, and I want to hear your side of it. Have you got twenty minutes now, or shall we make it later today?"

"I've got some difficult feedback and I've been sitting on it for longer than I should have — which is my fault, not yours. Can I give it to you now?"

All three name the seriousness, name the subject, and leave room for the other person to be a participant rather than a recipient. The third also does something valuable: it takes responsibility for the delay, which is honest and disarms the entirely reasonable "why am I only hearing this now?"

The middle — evidence, impact, silence

State the specific thing that happened. State its effect. Then **stop and ask**.

The stopping is the skill. The instinct is to keep going — to add a second example, to soften, to explain that you know they are under pressure. Every additional sentence after the message dilutes it, and the silence you are uncomfortable with is the silence in which the other person is actually absorbing what you said.

Then ask an open question and mean it: *"What's your read on it?"* Roughly a third of the time you will learn something that changes your view. That is not a failure of the conversation; it is the reason you are having one rather than sending a message.

The close — one thing, one date

End with a specific agreed change and a specific point at which you will both look at it again. Then write two or three lines to them afterwards confirming what you agreed. Not a formal record — a short message. It ensures you both left with the same understanding, which is otherwise about a coin flip.

Managing your own state

You will be tense, and the person will read it. Three practical things:

- **Do not have the conversation angry.** If you are, postpone it by a day — but only a day. Anger makes you say the characterisation instead of the fact, and the characterisation is what gets remembered and repeated.
- **Slow your speech down deliberately.** Anxiety speeds delivery, and fast delivery reads as aggression and prevents the other person processing. Aim for slower than feels natural.
- **Do not schedule anything immediately after.** A hard conversation that must end at eleven o'clock sharp will be rushed at exactly the point where it needs room.

When it goes sideways

What happens	What to do
They counter-attack "Well, you never told me / you do the same thing"	Some of it is probably true. Concede what is true, immediately and without defensiveness — it costs you nothing and buys enormous credibility. Then return: <i>"You're right that I should have raised this sooner. It's still the case that the handover didn't happen, and that's what I need us to fix."</i> The pattern is concede, then return , as many times as needed.
They go silent	Wait longer than is comfortable — ten full seconds. If still nothing: <i>"I've landed a lot on you. Would it be better to take this away and come back tomorrow?"</i> Do not fill the silence with your own reasoning; you will end up negotiating against yourself.
They dispute the facts	Take it seriously; you may be wrong. <i>"Let's slow down — tell me what happened from your side."</i> If you genuinely disagree on what occurred, do not force agreement in the room. Say you will check, and check.
They raise something protected Health, discrimination, retaliation, pay, safety, a complaint	Stop the conversation. Not later — at that moment. Thank them, tell them you are going to make sure it goes to the right place, and do not continue with your original agenda. Your obligations from that point are set out in the Employee Handbook (§7.5, §9, §35.1, §129.1), and you have them whether or not you think the point was raised tactically.
They make it about you personally	Do not defend and do not escalate. <i>"I might be getting some of this wrong and I'm happy to talk about that separately. Right now I want to stay on the specific thing."</i> If it persists, end the conversation and take advice.
You realise mid-conversation you are wrong	Say so, immediately and plainly. <i>"I've had this wrong. I'm sorry — I came in with a picture that isn't accurate."</i> Managers fear this destroys authority. It does the opposite, and people talk about it for years.

Eight conversations nobody prepares you for

These sit outside the situations addressed in policy, come up constantly, and are handled badly by default.

1 · The role is changing and it will feel like a demotion

A reorganisation narrows someone's scope. The instinct is to sell it as an opportunity. Do not — they can see what happened, and the mismatch between your framing and their reality destroys trust in everything else you say. Name it accurately: *"This is a smaller scope than you had, and I'm not going to dress it up. Here's the reasoning, here's what I think it means for you, and here's what I don't yet know."* Then, critically, tell them what it is *not*: if it is not a judgment on their performance, say so explicitly and repeatedly, because they will assume it is. If it partly is, say that too — ambiguity here is crueller than the truth.

2 · Telling the team someone has gone

You cannot say why, and everyone knows there is a why. The failure modes are the vague reassurance ("Alex has decided to move on, we wish them well") which nobody believes and which invites speculation, and the accidental disclosure, which is a serious breach of the departed person's privacy and is unlawful in some circumstances.

What works is naming the constraint rather than pretending it does not exist: *"Alex left the company on Friday. I can't go into the reasons — that's private to Alex and it would be wrong of me to discuss it, and I'd say the same about any of you. What I can talk about is what happens to the work, and I know that's the immediate question."* Then move directly and concretely to coverage. Ambiguity about the work is what actually generates anxiety; ambiguity about the reason generates gossip you cannot prevent anyway.

3 · Giving feedback to your own manager

Ask permission, be specific, and offer it as data rather than as a verdict. *"Can I give you some feedback on how the planning session landed? ... When the decision changed at the end without the reasoning, my team spent the following week trying to reverse-engineer it. If the reasoning had been said out loud it would have saved a lot of churn."*

Note the structure: an observable event, a concrete consequence, an implied fix. No characterisation of them, no accumulated grievance list, no "the team feels" — speak for yourself unless you have been asked to represent others.

4 · The personal thing — hygiene, volume, mannerism

The conversation managers avoid the longest, at the greatest cost to the person, who is usually the only one who does not know. Be brief, be private, be kind, and do not build up to it — a long preamble makes it monumentally worse.

"I'm going to say something awkward because I'd want someone to tell me. There's an issue with [specific thing], and it's noticeable to others. I'm not raising it as a performance matter — I just think you'd want to know." Then stop. Do not elaborate, do not seek reassurance that it was okay to say, and change the subject when they signal they want to. If there is any indication of an underlying medical cause, that is an accommodation matter and it stops being your conversation.

5 · Delivering a decision you disagree with

Two dishonest options and one honest one. You can pretend to agree, which fails the moment you are asked a follow-up question and costs you credibility permanently. You can distance yourself — "they've decided, nothing I could do" — which is disloyal, teaches the team you are powerless, and makes you useless as a conduit. Or you can be straight about the distinction between agreement and commitment:

"I'll be honest — this isn't the call I'd have made, and I argued for something different. It's been decided and I understand the reasoning even though I weigh it differently. It's the decision, so we're going to make it work, and I'll keep pushing on [the specific part I think is wrong]." This is honest, it is loyal to the decision, and it does not require you to lie. Say it once, then commit — repeating your dissent every week is a slower form of undermining.

6 · Someone resigns and you want them to stay

First, react well, whatever you are feeling. The most common manager error is a visibly cold response, which converts a departing advocate into a departing critic. Second, understand before you counter: *"Before anything else — what made you start looking?"* The answer is usually not the thing in the offer letter.

Then be careful about counter-offering. If the reason is money and everything else is right, a counter may be appropriate and it goes through Compensation, not through you. If the reason is the work, the manager, the growth or the team, a counter fixes nothing and buys a few months of a person who has already decided. And if you would not have proactively given them what you are now offering to prevent them leaving, ask yourself what that says — the rest of the team will draw the conclusion that resigning is the mechanism for getting paid.

7 · Killing someone's project

People attach to work they created, and the loss is real. Give the reasoning fully and honestly — the version people resent is "priorities have changed," which tells them nothing and implies the decision was arbitrary. Distinguish the work from the person explicitly, because they will not: *"This isn't a judgment on how you did it. The work was good; the bet didn't pay off, and that was a call I made, not you."* Then give them something to do with the effort — what was learned, where it goes next, what they take with them. And say it yourself, before a roadmap document says it for you.

8 · The long-tenured person the job has outgrown

Someone has been here twelve years, is loyal and well-liked, and the role has changed underneath them. This is handled badly more often than almost anything else, usually by being avoided until it becomes a formal process, which is both unkind and legally fraught given the age profile of the population it affects.

Have it early and have it honestly, as a conversation about the job rather than about the person: *"The job you're doing now is genuinely different from the one you were hired into, and I don't think we've ever properly talked about that. I want to understand how you're finding it and what would need to be true for it to work well for you."* Then listen. There are frequently good options — a redefined role, a specialism, a mentoring scope, a deliberate transition — that are only available if the conversation happens two years early rather than two months late. Take advice before any version of this conversation that touches on someone's future in the role.

FAILURE MODE · THE CONVERSATION YOU HAD IN YOUR HEAD

You have rehearsed it so thoroughly, and been so troubled by it, that afterwards you are certain the message landed — because it felt enormous to you. The person heard a mildly critical remark in an otherwise normal meeting and has forgotten it by Thursday.

The check costs one sentence: *"I want to make sure I've been clear — what's your understanding of what we've agreed?"* If what comes back is not what you meant, say it again, plainer. This single question resolves the most common failure in this entire chapter.

PART FOUR · HARD GROUND

10 · Discipline

Corrective action is a process with a defined sequence. What the sequence cannot tell you is which situation you are actually in, how severe it is relative to comparable cases, and how to keep working with the person afterwards.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

The progressive sequence and each step's meaning, the categories warranting immediate termination, the consistency requirement and the discipline register, documentation standards, suspension rules, and the requirement for People Partner review beyond verbal coaching are all in Employee Handbook §66, with the procedure at SOP-HR-05 (§137) and the corrective action form at §150. Security policy violations additionally engage Information Security Manual SA-10.

Conduct, capability or context

The first and most consequential decision is which of three things you are looking at, because they run on different tracks and the wrong track is both unfair and legally exposed.

Category	The question	Track
Conduct	<i>Did they choose?</i> A rule was known and broken, or a standard of behaviour was not met. The person could have done otherwise.	Corrective action under §66.
Capability	<i>Can they?</i> They are trying and cannot yet meet the standard. No choice is involved.	Performance management and, if it comes to it, an improvement plan under §65. Not discipline.
Context	<i>Could anyone?</i> The system, the workload, an unresolved accommodation, a missing tool, a broken dependency or an untrained-for change is producing the outcome.	Your problem to fix. Neither track applies.

Two tests to separate them. **The other-person test:** would a competent colleague in the same seat, with the same information and constraints, have produced the same result? If yes, it is context. **The knowledge test:** did the person know the standard, at the time, with enough specificity to comply? If you cannot point to where and when they were told, you have a clarity problem, and a warning for breaching an unstated rule will not survive review.

FAILURE MODE · DISCIPLINING A CAPABILITY PROBLEM

Someone is trying hard and producing weak work. Frustration accumulates, and eventually a written warning appears.

Three things have gone wrong. It is unfair — you are penalising someone for the absence of a skill nobody gave them. It does not work — a warning does not install a capability, so the situation continues and now with a damaged relationship. And it is exposed: if this ever reaches a tribunal, the file shows a company that punished someone for not being able to do a job rather than supporting or reassigning them, which is a poor position from which to defend a subsequent dismissal.

Before you act: the confounders

Your People Partner will check these, and you should check them first because it will change what you propose.

- Has this person raised any concern, complaint or query in the past twelve months — including informally, including to someone else?
- Have they requested or taken leave, or requested an accommodation, or disclosed anything about their health?
- Have they recently discussed pay, applied for an internal role, or declined something?
- Has anything changed about their work, tools, team or manager in the period concerned?
- Is the standard I am enforcing written down anywhere, and were they told?
- Have I enforced it with anyone else, and what happened?
- Am I responding to this incident, or to an accumulation I never raised?

The last one deserves emphasis. A great deal of disproportionate discipline is a manager finally acting on eight months of unspoken irritation, triggered by a minor incident. The person experiences a wildly excessive response to a small thing, because from their side that is exactly what it is.

Calibrating severity

Consistency across the Company is maintained through the discipline register and your People Partner. Your contribution is a defensible starting proposal, built from four factors rather than from how annoyed you are.

Factor	What raises or lowers the response
Intent	Deliberate, reckless, careless or mistaken. A genuine mistake honestly reported is categorically different from the same outcome concealed — and treating them the same is how you teach a team to conceal.
Consequence	Actual and potential harm: to a customer, a colleague, the Company, or to the integrity of a control. Potential harm counts even where luck intervened.
Clarity of the standard	Explicitly trained and acknowledged, versus custom and practice, versus something everyone assumed. This factor alone frequently moves the response a full step.

History and response

Prior similar issues, and — importantly — how the person responded when it was raised. Someone who understood and corrected is in a different position from someone who disputed the facts and repeated it.

JUDGMENT CALL · THE GOOD PERFORMER WHO DID SOMETHING SERIOUS

Your strongest contributor has done something that would earn anyone else a formal warning. Every instinct says the loss to the team would be disproportionate.

Performance is not a defence and cannot lower the outcome. It can legitimately inform what happens *around* it — the support offered, the tone, the development framing — but the outcome itself must be what any comparable employee would receive, because the discipline register makes the difference visible and because the rest of your team can already see it. Every manager who has quietly excused a star has taught the team exactly what the rules are worth.

If you genuinely believe the standard outcome is wrong here, the argument to make is that it would be wrong for *anyone* in this situation — which is a legitimate argument to put to your People Partner, and a very different one from an exception for this person.

Holding the conversation

The required elements and documentation are specified at SOP-HR-05. Four points of craft:

- **Say what it is at the start.** "This is a formal conversation about X and there may be a written outcome." People are entitled to know the register they are in. Discovering afterwards that an apparently normal conversation was a disciplinary step is both procedurally unsound and a permanent breach of trust.
- **Present facts, then genuinely listen.** Not as ritual. Around a fifth of the time the response materially changes the picture, and a manager who has clearly already decided converts a correctable situation into a grievance.
- **Record what they said, including the parts that help them.** A record that captures only the case against reads as a construction, and it will be read that way by everyone who sees it afterwards.
- **Be precise about what happens next.** What changes, by when, what you will do, what happens if it recurs, and when you will next discuss it. Vagueness here is the most common reason the same conversation happens again.

Repairing the relationship afterwards

Almost nothing is written about this, and it determines whether corrective action works. A warning is supposed to be a correction, not the beginning of an exit — but if you treat the person differently afterwards, it becomes one, and it also starts to look like the exit was always the plan.

- **Do not shrink their work.** The instinct after a discipline event is to reduce exposure. If it is not a job requirement, do not do it — it is visible to everyone, it is experienced as a second punishment, and it converts a conduct matter into a de facto demotion nobody sanctioned.
- **Acknowledge correction explicitly.** If the required change happens, say so, in writing, within the timeframe you set. This is a stated part of the process and it is the step managers most often skip. Its absence teaches the person that compliance is unrewarded and the outcome was predetermined.

- **Do not keep referring back.** Once addressed, it is addressed. Repeated allusion is experienced as harassment and, if the person subsequently leaves, is exactly the pattern their account will describe.
- **Say the relationship survives.** Out loud, once: *"That conversation was necessary and it's done. It doesn't change how I see you or what I think you're capable of."* Most people assume the opposite by default.
- **Do not tell the team.** Discipline is confidential. If colleagues were affected and need to know something was addressed, that is a People Partner conversation about what, if anything, can properly be said.

PART FOUR · HARD GROUND

11 · Terminations

The decision is reviewed, the process is defined and the conversation itself has a required shape. What is left to you is whether it is genuinely the right call, everything that surrounds the twenty minutes, and the month afterwards.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

The requirement for People Partner review before any decision is communicated, the categories additionally requiring Legal review, final pay deadlines by work state, PTO payout, benefits, property recovery, references, rehire eligibility and exit interviews are in Employee Handbook §23, with the offboarding sequence at SOP-HR-06 (§138). The required shape of the delivery conversation itself is at §132. Access revocation timing is Information Security Manual §2.4.3. This chapter does not restate any of it.

The seven-question pre-decision test

Before you propose a termination, answer these honestly. If you cannot answer several of them well, the problem is not that the decision is wrong — it may well be right — but that you are not yet in a position to make it, and proceeding anyway is how organisations lose cases they should have won.

#	Question
1	Did they know? Can you point to the specific occasions on which the gap was made clear to them, with dates? Not "they must have known." Not "it was obvious." Where and when were they told?
2	Did they have a real chance? Was the support offered genuine and sufficient, and did the standard remain stable? A moving target is not a chance.
3	Is it documented contemporaneously? Does the written record exist from when things happened, or was it assembled recently? A file that begins three weeks ago describing eleven months of problems tells its own story.
4	Is it consistent? Has anyone else done substantially the same thing and remained? If so, what distinguishes them, and would that distinction persuade a stranger?
5	What happened in the last three months? Any complaint, leave, accommodation, pay discussion, absence, internal application or protected activity. This question is asked in every case and answered before anyone commits to anything.
6	Has the reason stayed the same? Does what you are saying now match what you wrote in the review, the improvement plan and the 1:1 notes? A rationale that shifts is treated as evidence that the real reason is unstated.

7

Is anything about the environment mine? Unclear expectations, absent feedback, a role that changed, a system nobody could succeed in, a conflict I did not address. Answer this one properly even though it is uncomfortable — and especially if the answer is yes, because it may change the right outcome.

FAILURE MODE · THE FILE THAT STARTS TOO LATE

A manager tolerates a problem for a year without documenting it, then decides to act, and produces four detailed memoranda in three weeks describing the whole history.

Every one of those memoranda may be accurate. The pattern is nonetheless close to indefensible: the record shows a manager who documented nothing until they wanted an outcome. If this describes your file, say so to your People Partner plainly rather than presenting it as contemporaneous. The situation is usually recoverable — with time, a properly run process and an honest account of where you got to. It is not recoverable if you conceal it and it emerges later.

Timing and sequencing

Several logistical decisions sit with the manager and are frequently got wrong.

- **Give Payroll and People real notice.** Final-pay deadlines vary by work state and some are immediate. Deciding on a Friday for a Monday exit can make it impossible to pay someone lawfully. The lead times required are set out in §23.4 and SOP-HR-06; build your timeline backwards from them, not forwards from your own readiness.
- **Do not do it on a Friday because it feels tidier.** It is tidier for you. It leaves the person with a weekend, no ability to contact anyone about benefits or pay, and no way to begin doing anything about their situation. Mid-week, earlier in the day, is kinder and produces measurably better outcomes.
- **Do not do it immediately before a significant personal event** you know about — a wedding, a bereavement, a medical procedure — if a short delay is possible. Sometimes it is not. Where it is, take it.
- **Coordinate access revocation with the conversation, not before it.** Someone discovering they have been locked out before anyone has spoken to them is a serious failure. The sequencing rules, including the exception for privileged users on involuntary separations, are in the Information Security Manual §2.4.3 — follow them, and make sure the timing is agreed with Security before the meeting is booked.
- **Have the room and the logistics settled in advance.** Where, who, what happens immediately afterwards, how they get home, who has their belongings. Improvising these in the moment is where dignity is lost.

The manager's day-of runbook

The conversation's required content and shape are set at §132. What follows is what surrounds it.

When	What you do
The day before	Confirm every logistical element with People and Security. Write your opening two sentences and read them out loud once — this is the only part you should script, and hearing it prevents the common failure of a rambling or apologetic opening. Clear your afternoon.

Immediately before	Do not rehearse justifications; you are not going to argue the case. Do not check whether you feel ready. You will not.
During	Follow §132. The two additions worth naming: do not use the word "unfortunately," and do not ask how they are feeling — both invite a discussion of the decision that cannot go anywhere and prolong something that should be brief.
Immediately after	Do not go back to your desk and start work. Tell your own manager it is done. Write down anything the person said that People need to know — particularly anything that sounded like a complaint, which changes what happens next.
Within the hour	Tell the team, if the sequencing agreed with People allows. Do not let them find out from a calendar deletion or a Slack deactivation, which is how it usually happens and which is horrible.
The same week	Speak to each remaining team member individually. Coverage, reassurance where you can honestly give it, and a chance for them to say something. Do not do this only as a group.

Reactions in the room

If they...	Then
Ask "is this a discussion?"	Answer honestly and immediately: "No. The decision is made. I'm here to tell you and to make sure you have what you need." Ambiguity here is cruel — it produces someone arguing for their job in a conversation where that is not available.
Argue the facts	Do not re-litigate and do not concede. "I understand you see it differently. The decision isn't going to change today. If you think the process was wrong, here's who to talk to."
Become distressed	Stop. Offer water, time, a private room, a call to someone. Do not continue through it because there is an agenda. The logistics can be sent in writing or covered by People.
Become angry or threatening	End the meeting calmly. Do not respond in kind, do not stay alone with someone who is escalating. Where there is any indication of risk, follow §81 and involve Security immediately.
Allege discrimination or retaliation	Do not respond to the substance, do not defend, do not concede. "I hear you and I'm going to make sure that's passed on properly." Then report it that day. It changes the Company's obligations regardless of the termination.
Ask you for a reference	Do not answer in the room. The Company's position on references is set at §23.8 and it is not yours to vary.

Telling the team

Say it directly, say it early, say what you can, and be explicit about what you cannot say and why. Then spend most of the conversation on the work, because the unspoken question in the room is "what does this mean for me" and the second is "who is doing their job."

Three things not to do. Do not disparage the person who has left, however tempting the implicit self-justification — it is a breach and it tells everyone how you will speak about them. Do not over-reassure ("nobody else needs to worry"), which you cannot promise and which will be remembered if it turns out untrue. And do not use it as a motivational instrument, explicitly or by implication; teams read that accurately and it does lasting damage.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · TO THE TEAM, THE SAME DAY

"I want to tell you directly rather than have you work it out. Sam left the company today. It was the Company's decision, and I'm not going to say more than that — the reasons are confidential and they'd be confidential if it were any of you, which matters.

I know that raises questions and I'd rather you asked me than each other. What I can be concrete about is the work: here's how we're covering it for the next two weeks, and here's what I'm asking each of you to pick up. If you want to talk to me one-to-one about any of this, my door is open today and tomorrow — come and find me."

Afterwards, for you

Two things worth saying plainly. First, terminating someone is supposed to feel bad, and the managers who find it easy are usually the ones doing it badly. If you have been through one, the flatness that follows for a few days is normal; talk to your own manager, and the Employee Assistance Programme is available to you as much as to anyone else.

Second, do a genuine post-mortem within a fortnight, while it is fresh. Where did this become inevitable, and could it have been caught earlier? Was the hire wrong, the role wrong, the onboarding wrong, or the feedback too late? Did I avoid a conversation in month three that would have changed month eleven? Write the answer down somewhere you will see it. The main value of a termination to the rest of your team is what you change because of it.

PART FIVE · PROTECTING EVERYONE

12 · Documentation

Documentation is not paperwork you produce when a situation becomes formal. It is a habit you keep so that situations either do not become formal, or are survivable when they do. Almost every chapter in this handbook is easier for a manager who writes things down.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

Documentation standards for corrective action, the personnel file structure, employee access rights, retention schedules and legal holds are in Employee Handbook §66.4 and §21, with retention and disposal controls at Information Security Manual §7. The forms library is at Part XIX. This chapter is about how to write, not what to file.

What to write down, and what not to

Write it down	Do not
A specific expectation you set, and when	Your theory about why someone is behaving as they are
A concrete instance — good or bad — with a date	Characterisations of personality, attitude or character
What you agreed and by when	Anything about health, family, religion, pregnancy or disability
What the person said in response, including where it helps them	Speculation about someone's plans, ambitions or circumstances
A decision and the reasoning available at the time	Second-hand accounts stated as fact
Recognition and things done well	Anything you would not say to the person
Coverage arrangements and business reasons for them	Any reference to someone having raised a concern, taken leave or requested an accommodation

The last item on the right needs emphasis, because managers do it with good intentions. Writing "Priya has been under pressure since returning from leave, so I've reduced her scope" reads to you as compassionate context. In a record it reads as the leave causing an adverse action, and it will be the strongest document in the case. Write the business reason: what changed about the work, and why.

PRACTICE TOOL · THE TWO-MINUTE HABIT

After any conversation that mattered — feedback given, an expectation set, a concern raised, a decision made — write three lines and send them to the person:

"Following up on our conversation: we agreed the migration doc lands by the 14th, and that you'll flag it to me at the halfway point if it's slipping. I'll get you the access you need by Friday. Let's check in on the 16th."

This does five things simultaneously. It confirms you both heard the same thing. It gives them a fair chance, because expectations they can re-read are expectations they can meet. It creates a contemporaneous record with no effort. It is visible to them, so nothing in your file is a secret. And it commits you to your half, which is the part managers most often drop.

Rewriting a bad note: a worked example

The difference between a useless record and a strong one is a matter of technique, not effort. Here is a note of the kind managers write routinely, and the same events written properly.

THE NOTE AS WRITTEN

"Had another difficult conversation with Marcus today. His attitude has really deteriorated since he didn't get the team lead role and he's clearly not over it. Very defensive when I raised the client complaint, wouldn't take any responsibility. Been going downhill since he came back from his leave in March — I know things have been hard at home but this can't continue. Told him he needs to sort it out. Getting to the point where I'm not sure he's right for the team."

Nine separate problems. It records the manager's inference ("attitude has deteriorated," "clearly not over it") and no observable facts. It ties the concern to a protected absence and to a failed promotion, creating two ready-made retaliation narratives. It discloses personal family circumstances that have no place in a performance record. Its account of the conversation ("told him he needs to sort it out") shows no specific expectation was set, which means the document proves the person was never given a fair chance. It ends with a conclusion about the person's future unsupported by anything above it. And there is no date, no instance, and nothing the employee could act on.

THE SAME EVENTS, WRITTEN PROPERLY

14 May — 1:1, 30 mins, my office

Raised the client complaint received 9 May regarding the delayed Henderson report. Set out the facts: report was due 2 May, delivered 8 May, client was not notified of the delay in advance.

Marcus's response: said the input data from the finance team arrived four days late and he had been chasing it. Said he had not flagged the delay to me or the client because he expected to recover the time. Accepted that the client should have been told.

Agreed: (1) for any deliverable at risk of slipping more than one day, he will notify me and the client at the point he knows, not at the deadline; (2) I will raise the finance input timing with their team lead this week; (3) we review how this is working in our 1:1 on 11 June.

Also noted: this is the second late delivery this quarter (the Ashcroft summary, delivered 3 April, two days late). Told him directly that a pattern is forming and that I wanted to name it now rather than at review time. He acknowledged this.

Summary sent to Marcus by email, 14 May.

The second version is longer to read and took about four minutes to write. Everything in it is factual and dated. It contains the employee's account including the parts that explain the delay. It records a specific, measurable expectation and a review date. It records the manager's own commitment. It names the pattern explicitly, which is what makes any later step fair. It says nothing about attitude, leave, family or the promotion. And the employee has a copy, so nothing in it can be a surprise.

If this situation ever escalates, the second note is the reason the process is defensible. If it does not escalate — which is the more likely outcome, precisely because the expectation was clear — the note is the reason.

Words that cost you the case

Avoid	Because
"Attitude," "not a team player," "difficult"	Unfalsifiable characterisations. They cannot be corrected, they cannot be defended, and they are the classic vehicle for unexamined bias. Describe the behaviour and its effect.
"Not a culture fit"	Reads as a proxy for a protected characteristic and is treated as one. There is no version of this phrase that survives scrutiny.
"Lacks executive presence," "needs more polish," "too aggressive"	Applied unevenly across gender, race and background with well-documented consistency. If there is a real underlying issue, it can be stated behaviourally; if it cannot, there was no issue.
"Since returning from leave," "given her situation," "with everything going on at home"	Creates a documented link between a protected status and an adverse view. Even where kindly meant.
"Not committed," "not available," "not putting the hours in"	Frequently a proxy for caregiving responsibility, disability or religious observance. State the specific work requirement that was not met.

"Overqualified," "not hungry any more," "close to retirement"	Age-coded. Every one of them appears in successful age discrimination claims.
"Everyone knows," "several people have said," "there's a general feeling"	Unattributable and unanswerable. If you have specific reports, you have specific reports and possibly an escalation duty; if you have atmosphere, you have nothing.
"I've told him a hundred times"	Hyperbole in a record destroys the credibility of the accurate parts. Write the two dates you actually told him.

Channel discipline

Where you write something matters nearly as much as what you write.

- **Nothing conclusive in an instant message.** Chat is written to be read once and it is retained, discoverable and quotable. It is the natural home of the offhand sentence you would never put in a document, which is precisely why it produces the most damaging exhibits. Assessments, conclusions and decisions go in the systems built for them.
- **Never in a personal channel or on a personal device.** Records about employees belong in Company systems, under the retention schedule. A manager keeping a private file on someone is a serious problem, whatever the intention.
- **Do not vent in writing.** Not to a peer, not to your own manager, not in a thread. The venting message is the one that gets read aloud, and it is read as evidence of what you actually thought. If you need to vent, do it in a conversation.
- **One place per person.** A record spread across email, chat, notebooks and a document nobody can find is functionally no record at all. Keep your evidence file in one place, in the Company system, per person.
- **Assume they will read it, because they may.** Employees have rights of access to personnel records in many jurisdictions (§21.2). This is not a reason to write less; it is a reason to write nothing you could not defend to their face.

JUDGMENT CALL · DOCUMENTING WHEN THINGS ARE GOING WELL

Managers document problems and rarely document success, which produces two distortions. The file reads as a prosecution when it is eventually assembled, and at review time the manager can recall three failures in detail and no achievements specifically.

Aim for a genuine balance — roughly as many positive entries as negative. This is not defensive record-keeping; it is the raw material of a fair review, a promotion case and a reference. And it changes what you notice: a manager who has committed to recording three good things a month starts looking for them.

PART FIVE · PROTECTING EVERYONE

13 · Legal Risk Sense

You do not need to know employment law. You need to recognise the shapes that create exposure — and almost all of them are created months before anyone thinks a legal issue exists, by an ordinary manager doing something reasonable without writing down why.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

The statutory framework, the areas of greatest state variation and the illustrative multi-state comparison are in Employee Handbook Appendix A (§§158–160). The manager obligations that carry no discretion are at §129.1. This chapter does not restate the law; it describes how cases are built and what managers do that builds them.

How a claim is actually built

The mental model most managers carry is wrong in a way that matters. They imagine a claim turns on proving that someone acted from prejudice — and since they know they did not, they feel safe.

Claims almost never work that way. Direct evidence of intent is vanishingly rare. What a claimant actually assembles is a **pattern**, out of ordinary documents created by managers who were not thinking about litigation:

1. Something protected happened — a complaint, a leave, an accommodation request, a disclosure, a pay conversation, an age, a pregnancy.
2. Something adverse followed — a rating, a warning, a reduced scope, a lost opportunity, a termination.
3. The gap between them was short.
4. The stated reason is thin, undocumented before the fact, or has changed over time.
5. Someone else in a comparable position was treated differently.

That is the whole structure, and none of the five elements requires anyone to have been prejudiced. Which is the uncomfortable and useful point: **a manager acting entirely in good faith can construct all five**. The protection is not your intent. It is the record you made at the time, and the consistency of your decisions.

The seven patterns

1 · Temporal proximity

An adverse action follows closely after protected activity. Timing alone is often enough to shift the burden onto the Company to explain.

What to do: when you notice that a decision you are about to make follows something protected, do not abandon the decision — that is its own unfairness, and it teaches people that raising concerns makes them untouchable. Slow down, document the pre-existing basis, and take advice on sequencing. If the concern genuinely predates the protected activity, the record needs to show that, and it needs to have shown it before the activity happened.

2 · The shifting rationale

The reason given at the time was performance. In the exit conversation it was restructuring. In the response to the claim it was conduct. Each version may have been partly true; together they are treated as evidence that none of them is the real one.

What to do: settle the reason before you communicate anything, write it once, and say the same thing every time. If there are genuinely two reasons, say both from the start.

3 · The inconsistent comparator

Two people did substantially the same thing. One was disciplined; one was not. The distinction was real in your head and appears nowhere in writing.

What to do: when you decide to treat similar-looking situations differently, write down the distinction at the time, in one line. This is a thirty-second act that resolves the single most common evidentiary problem in employment claims.

4 · The stray remark

An offhand comment — about someone's age, their plans for a family, their accent, how long they intend to keep working, their energy levels, whether they are "still up for this" — made months earlier, in a corridor, jokingly. It resurfaces as evidence of the state of mind behind a later decision.

What to do: the discipline is at the level of habit, not policy. Assume everything you say about a person's characteristics is quotable. If you have already said something you regret, tell your People Partner rather than hoping it was not heard.

5 · The manager who knew

An employee mentioned something — a concern, a health issue, that they were struggling — in passing, informally, to their manager, who did nothing because it did not seem like a formal report. The Company was on notice from that moment, and its failure to act is the claim.

What to do: route it. The threshold for escalation is far lower than managers assume, and there is no penalty for escalating something that turns out to be nothing. This is the single most common way individual manager judgment creates corporate liability.

6 · The paper trail that starts late

Nothing in the file for two years, then a dense sequence of documentation over six weeks, then a termination. The timeline is visible on the face of the record and is close to impossible to explain away.

What to do: document continuously, from the first concern. If you are already in this position, be honest about it with your People Partner rather than adding to the sequence.

7 · The unwritten accommodation

An informal adjustment — flexible hours, a lighter travel load, a changed duty — was agreed verbally and generously, recorded nowhere. Later, a new manager arrives, or the arrangement becomes inconvenient, and it is withdrawn. Now there is a documented removal of an adjustment with no documented basis, and quite possibly a failure to have run the interactive process at all.

What to do: any adjustment for a health, disability, religious or caregiving reason goes through the Accommodations process (§9), even when you could simply say yes and even when the person asks you to keep it informal. Informality protects nobody: not the employee, whose arrangement is unenforceable, and not you.

FAILURE MODE · THE KIND EXCEPTION THAT BECOMES THE PROBLEM

Every one of the seven patterns has a version created by a manager being generous. Quietly letting someone work adjusted hours. Not documenting a warning because it felt harsh. Overlooking a lapse because of what was going on at home. Giving a better rating than the evidence supported to avoid a difficult period.

Each is decent and each removes the record that would later have protected everyone. The resolution is not to stop being generous — it is to **make the generosity official**. Route the adjustment. Write down the distinction. Say what the real rating was and what you have decided to do about it. Kindness and documentation are not in tension; undocumented kindness is just an unenforceable promise.

The manager's five-second checks

Habitual questions, not a process. Ask them in the moment.

- Am I about to write a characterisation instead of a fact?
- Has anything protected happened to this person in the last three months?
- Would I do this for the person sitting next to them?
- Is the reason I am giving now the same one I gave before?
- Am I making an informal arrangement that should be a formal one?
- Did I just learn something that I am obliged to pass on?
- Would this sentence be comfortable to read out loud?

PART FIVE · PROTECTING EVERYONE

14 · California and New York Triggers

Two jurisdictions where a manager’s ordinary behaviour has to change, not just the Company’s paperwork. This chapter lists only the triggers — the moments where you must pause because of where someone sits.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES — AND AN IMPORTANT CAUTION

The authoritative rules, thresholds, deadlines and comparisons are in Employee Handbook §159 and §160, and the current, complete, per-state matrix is maintained on the People Portal. State and city employment law in California and New York changes materially every January, and both jurisdictions added obligations that take effect during 2026. This chapter is a set of behavioural prompts with a deliberately short shelf life: it tells you *when to stop and check*, never what the answer is. Never quote a figure or a deadline from memory in either state.

Why these two are different for you personally

In most jurisdictions, the state-specific complexity is absorbed by Payroll, Leave Administration and Legal, and a manager can operate on general principles. California and New York are the two places where that is not safe, for three reasons: the obligations attach to *supervisor conduct* rather than only to Company process; several of them are triggered by something an employee says to you rather than by a form; and the remedies are individual, immediate and expensive. A manager's five-minute decision genuinely changes the outcome in these two states more than anywhere else.

Note also that these rules follow the **employee's work location, not yours and not the Company's**. A manager in Texas with one report in Los Angeles is managing under California rules for that person, and this is one of the most commonly missed facts in distributed teams.

California — where you must stop

The moment	What changes for you
You are about to ask a non-exempt person to work a long day, a sixth or seventh consecutive day, or through a break	California's daily overtime and break-premium regime means the cost and the legal position are different from almost everywhere else, and missed breaks generate a premium per day. Do not treat "just push through today" as a neutral request. Check §29–§30 before you ask, and never imply that skipping a break is helpful.
Anyone mentions pregnancy, a serious health condition, or family care	California entitlements can run <i>consecutively</i> with federal leave rather than concurrently, so the total absence may be far longer than your instinct assumes. Plan coverage on that basis and never state a return date to the person or to the team. Route immediately (§35.1); the Company's obligation begins when you are told.
You are deciding a termination or any separation date	Final pay is due immediately on involuntary termination in California. This constrains your timeline absolutely — you cannot decide today for tomorrow. Build backwards from Payroll's lead time (§23.4). Accrued vacation is a wage and is paid out; never suggest otherwise.

You are discussing a candidate's or employee's pay	Salary history questions are prohibited, and pay scales must be provided on request. Do not improvise. Route to Talent Acquisition or Compensation (§14.6, §26.2).
A candidate's background check surfaces something	California's fair-chance rules require an individualised assessment and a specific notice sequence with defined waiting periods. You have no role in this beyond not acting on it. Do not communicate anything to the candidate (§16.2–§16.3).
You are tempted to mention a non-compete or "you can't go and work for them"	Non-competes are void in California, and there are affirmative obligations around them. Never raise the subject, never imply a restriction, and never draft anything (§15.1).
Anything happens that involves a threat, intimidation, or a safety concern at a worksite	California requires a workplace violence prevention programme with specific incident logging and training obligations. Report through §81 immediately rather than handling it locally, and record it — the log is a compliance artefact, not just your note.
An employee is a victim of a crime, or a family member is, or discloses a pregnancy loss	California has discrete protected leave entitlements in these situations, several of them recently expanded. Do not assess whether it qualifies. Route it, ask only about duration and coverage, and never suggest they use vacation instead.
You are a new manager, or two years have passed	California mandates supervisor harassment prevention training on a defined cadence and content. Completion is a policy obligation and appears in your own performance record (§69.3).
A remote employee raises a cost of working from home	California requires indemnification of necessary business expenses, which reaches home internet and phone use for remote workers. Do not decline it yourself and do not agree a figure. Route to §117.

New York — where you must stop

The moment	What changes for you
An employee mentions a pregnancy-related medical appointment	New York provides paid prenatal leave as a distinct entitlement, separate from and in addition to sick leave, with further obligations in New York City. Do not tell someone to use sick time or PTO for prenatal care, and do not ask what the appointment is for. Route it.
Someone requests time off for caregiving, a legal proceeding, a public emergency, or a safety matter	New York City's safe and sick leave rules were expanded during 2026, both in permitted uses and in the addition of unpaid leave available immediately on hire. Your instinct about what "counts" is likely out of date. Do not decide; route and check.
You are about to write, approve or forward a job posting	New York requires the pay range in the posting and prohibits salary history inquiries. Never post informally — including in a personal network or a community channel — without Talent Acquisition (§14.6).
You want to use any automated or AI tool to screen, rank or shortlist candidates	New York City regulates automated employment decision tools, including bias audit and candidate notice requirements. You must not introduce any tool of your own — including a general-purpose AI assistant used to sift CVs. Everything goes through the approval route at §93 and §139.

You are considering monitoring, reviewing activity logs, or checking someone's messages	New York requires prior written notice of electronic monitoring. This is a Company obligation, but you must not initiate any individual monitoring yourself. Route to People and Security (§92).
Any conversation about reducing headcount, closing a site, or a significant restructuring	New York's mini-WARN thresholds and notice period are substantially more demanding than the federal ones, and remote employees generally count at their reporting site. The analysis must begin before anything is announced or discussed with the team (§23.3). Say nothing to anyone until Legal has been engaged.
A temporary schedule change is requested	New York City's framework changed in 2026 and the correct response is no longer what it was. Do not answer from memory. Take the request, say you will confirm, and check.
Annual training comes round	New York requires harassment prevention training annually for all employees, with specific content — a shorter cycle than most states. Team completion is your responsibility (§69.3).

SAY IT LIKE THIS · THE UNIVERSAL SAFE RESPONSE IN EITHER STATE

"That's a fair question and I want to give you the right answer rather than a quick one — the rules where you are are genuinely different from where I sit. Let me get it confirmed and come back to you by tomorrow. In the meantime, is there anything you need from me for coverage?"

This sentence is correct in every situation in both tables. It commits to nothing, it does not ask for information you must not have, it treats the person as reasonable, and it names a return time. If you remember one thing from this chapter, remember that you are allowed to not know.

FAILURE MODE · MANAGING A DISTRIBUTED TEAM ON YOUR OWN STATE'S RULES

You manage six people across four states. You know your own state's rules well and apply them everywhere, because that is the only frame you have.

Every one of the triggers above is missed for the people who are not near you, and the pattern also produces a second, quieter unfairness: your Californian report gets a different quality of management from your local report, for reasons neither of them can see. The practical fix is to keep a note of each person's work state next to their name in your own records, and to treat any question from someone outside your own state as a route-and-check by default.

PART SIX · ABSENCE AND DISTANCE

15 · Leave Management

You do not decide leave, assess eligibility or handle documentation, and this is the source of most manager anxiety about it — the sense of being responsible for something you cannot control. Your actual job is narrow, entirely doable, and consequential: recognise, route, cover, protect and welcome back.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

Every entitlement, eligibility rule, accrual, certification requirement, interaction and state programme is in Employee Handbook Part V (§§35–49), with the routing table at §35.1 and the administration procedure at SOP-HR-03 (§135). The manager's non-discretionary obligations are at §129.1 and in the Manager Action box at §35.1. This chapter contains no entitlements and adds only practice.

The discipline of not asking

The hardest part of leave for a decent manager is that ordinary human curiosity and ordinary human sympathy are both prohibited. Someone tells you something difficult, and the natural responses — "what's happened?", "is it serious?", "which hospital?", "how's your mother doing?" — are all inquiries you must not make.

This feels cold, and managers therefore drift into asking. Two things make it easier. First, understand why the line exists: information you acquire is information the Company is deemed to hold, and the moment you know a diagnosis, every subsequent decision you make about that person is coloured by it in a way that cannot be undone. The rule protects them, and it protects you. Second, recognise that **warmth and inquiry are different things**, and you are only prohibited from one.

SAY IT LIKE THIS · WARM WITHOUT INQUIRING

When someone discloses something difficult:

"I'm sorry — that sounds hard. You don't need to tell me anything about it, and I'd rather you didn't have to. The people who handle leave will be in touch and they'll look after the details. From me, the only things I need are roughly how long you think you'll be out and what you want me to do about your work. Everything else can wait."

When they volunteer more than you should hear:

"You're welcome to tell me whatever you want and I'm not going to stop you — I just want you to know you're not required to, and it doesn't affect anything."

When you want to check in during leave and are not sure if you may:

"Before you go — would you like me to stay in touch while you're out, or would you rather I left you alone? Either is completely fine and I'll do whatever you prefer."

That last question, asked before the leave starts, resolves the entire awkwardness of contact during absence. Ask it every time and write down the answer.

Three specific things not to say

- **"Let me know if you need anything"** as the whole of your response. It sounds supportive and it puts the burden on the person least able to carry it. Offer something specific instead.
- **"Don't worry, we'll manage"** in a tone that suggests strain. People routinely cut leave short because of a sense that the team is suffering. Say the coverage is handled and mean it.
- **"Just check in occasionally"** or anything that implies availability. Contact expectations during protected leave are set by the process, not by you, and a casual request creates real pressure. If work genuinely requires a handover conversation, arrange it through Leave Administration.

Coverage planning

This is your actual job during someone's absence and it is where managers under-invest, usually by spreading the work thinly across everyone and hoping.

Step	What good looks like
Separate must, should and can wait	Most roles contain less genuinely time-critical work than they appear to. Start by deciding what simply stops for the duration — and tell the affected stakeholders yourself rather than letting the covering person absorb the complaints.
Assign owners, not "the team"	Work distributed to a team is work owned by nobody. Name a person for each item. Collective coverage is the most common reason coverage fails.
Use it as development	A three-month absence is the best stretch opportunity you will get all year, and it is real rather than manufactured. Ask who wants it. Say explicitly that it is temporary and what happens at the end — otherwise you create a second problem on the return.
Adjust the coverer's goals in writing	If someone takes on additional scope, their own objectives change. Record it at the time. A person who covered for four months and was then rated against their original goals will not volunteer again, and will be right not to.
Recognise it explicitly	At the time, and again in the review cycle. Coverage is invisible work and it is disproportionately absorbed by the same people.
Do not permanently backfill	Restoration obligations are strict and the arrangements are directed by People, not by you (§39.7, SOP-HR-03 step 6). Do not reassign accounts, redistribute the role or announce a new owner in a way that would make restoration awkward.

Handling the team's reaction

Somebody is going to be resentful, and they will express it obliquely — a joke about who is doing the real work, a pointed question about how long "this" is going on for. Left unaddressed it becomes an atmosphere the returning person walks straight into.

Address it directly and once, on the principle rather than the individual: *"I know the cover is landing on people and I'm not pretending otherwise. Here's what I've stopped, here's what I've reassigned, and here's what I'm doing about the load. And I'd ask you to remember that protected leave is something every one of us might need — I'd make exactly the same arrangements for you, and I would not want a conversation about you happening in your absence."*

Do not disclose anything about the reason, the type or the expected duration, however much it would defuse the tension. And treat persistent hostility as a conduct matter rather than as understandable frustration, because that is what it becomes.

FAILURE MODE · THE QUIET PENALTY

Nobody says anything. But the person who was out for four months does not get the interesting project when they return, is not considered for the stretch assignment "while they get back up to speed," and their rating reflects a partial year of goals that were never pro-rated.

No single one of these is a decision anybody made. Together they are a documented pattern of disadvantage following protected leave, and they are the most common form the claim takes. The counter is deliberate: pro-rate goals in writing at the point of departure, and specifically ask yourself, at the next assignment and the next review, whether you are about to hold the absence against them without noticing.

Intermittent leave

The hardest version for a manager, because it is unpredictable and continuous. Two disciplines carry it.

Plan for the pattern, not for the person's return. Structure the work so that unpredictable absence is survivable: written handovers as a norm, no single points of failure, deadlines with buffer, and a deputy for anything time-critical. This is good practice anyway and it removes the frustration at source.

Never audit it yourself. The instinct to track whether the absences are "really" necessary, or to notice that they cluster around Fridays, is understandable and is exactly the behaviour that produces an interference claim. Certification, recertification and any concern about misuse are handled by Leave Administration (§39.5). If you have a genuine concern, raise it there — once — and then stop thinking about it.

Return-to-work craft

Managers plan carefully for the departure and not at all for the return, which is backwards: the return is where the retention risk sits, and someone returning from a long absence is at their most uncertain.

- **Make contact before day one.** A short message a week ahead — what has changed, what their first day looks like, who to expect. Returning to a full inbox with no orientation is a genuinely awful experience and it is entirely avoidable.
- **Do not schedule anything significant in week one.** No presentations, no customer meetings, no decisions. Give them a week to re-enter.
- **Brief them on what changed.** Structure, people, priorities, tooling, decisions taken. Write it down. Six months is a long time and nobody will think to tell them.
- **Ask what they want the team told.** Some people want the absence acknowledged; others want it never mentioned. Ask, follow it exactly, and tell the team what you have been asked to say.
- **Reset goals honestly.** The cycle has moved on. Agree a fair, pro-rated set explicitly rather than leaving them to discover in December that they are being measured against a year they were not present for.
- **Restrictions are not yours.** If they return with a medical restriction, that is an accommodation matter and it goes to the Accommodations team (§9, §47.6). Do not negotiate an informal adjustment, however straightforward it seems — see the unwritten-accommodation pattern in Chapter 13.

- **Check in at week six.** Not week one, when everyone is attentive. Week six, when everyone has moved on and the person is quietly struggling.

JUDGMENT CALL · THE PHASED RETURN YOU CANNOT RESOURCE

Someone is returning on reduced hours under an agreed arrangement, and you genuinely cannot cover the gap.

This is not yours to solve alone and it is not yours to solve by asking the employee to do more than the arrangement provides. Take it to your People Partner as a resourcing problem — which is what it is — and be specific about what cannot be covered and by when. What you must not do is let the pressure reach the returning person, directly or by atmosphere. They will feel it, they will try to absorb it, and both the health outcome and the legal position get worse from there.

PART SIX · ABSENCE AND DISTANCE

16 · Remote and Hybrid Management

Distributed teams do not fail because people work from home. They fail because managers keep running a team designed for a room, and the information that used to travel by proximity simply stops travelling.

WHERE THE RULE LIVES

The work location models and their definitions, approval and change of arrangements, the expectations that apply regardless of location, home workspace and home network requirements, injuries while working remotely, and the required inclusive practices for distributed teams are in Employee Handbook §128. Remote access and device controls are in Information Security Manual §2 and the Employee Handbook §100. This chapter is about the operating craft.

Writing a team operating agreement

The single highest-leverage thing a distributed manager can do, and most teams have never done it. Co-located teams have an operating system too — it is just implicit, absorbed by watching, and it does not survive distribution.

Write one page, with the team rather than for them, covering seven things. Then keep it where people can find it and revisit it twice a year.

PRACTICE TOOL · THE SEVEN QUESTIONS YOUR AGREEMENT ANSWERS

1. **When are we reachable?** Core hours per person, in their own time zone, published. Plus: what counts as urgent, and what someone should do if something is urgent outside those hours.
2. **What is the expected response time, by channel?** Chat, email, a tagged comment, a direct message. Without this, everyone invents a different answer and half the team feels permanently behind.
3. **Which decisions happen in writing?** Name them. Anything affecting more than two people is a good default.
4. **Where does information live?** One place per category, and nobody has to ask where something is.
5. **What are our meetings for?** Which ones are decision meetings, which are discussion, which could be a document. Say what happens if someone cannot attend.
6. **How do we disagree?** Written disagreement reads as harsher than it is. Agree a norm — a call for anything that has gone two rounds, and a convention that nobody is expected to take offence at directness in writing.
7. **When do we meet in person, and what is it for?** In-person time is expensive and should be spent on what it is uniquely good for: relationship, ambiguity, disagreement and planning. Not status.

Synchronous or written: deciding properly

Use a meeting when

Use writing when

There is genuine disagreement, or the subject is emotionally loaded	You are conveying information, however important
The problem is ill-defined and needs several people thinking aloud	The decision needs to be findable in six months
Something needs to be decided today	People are in different time zones and no slot is fair to everyone
Trust is being built or repaired	The thinking benefits from being properly structured first
Someone needs to be heard rather than informed	Some participants think better with time — which is most people

The default in most distributed teams is inverted: meetings for information and chat threads for decisions. Swapping those two around recovers several hours a week per person and produces a decision record nobody has to maintain separately.

Reading signal without proximity

In an office you absorb a great deal without noticing — who looks tired, who has stopped talking to whom, who is staying late, who seems flat. Remotely, none of that arrives, and managers substitute the wrong proxies: response speed, status colour, hours visibly online. Those measure availability and anxiety, not engagement or wellbeing.

Genuine signal	What it may mean
Their writing gets shorter and more transactional	Often the earliest indicator of disengagement or overload, and it is visible weeks before anything else.
They stop asking questions	Either they have stopped caring, or they no longer feel it is safe to not know. Both need a conversation.
They stop volunteering and only respond	Withdrawal. Particularly meaningful in someone who previously initiated.
Their 1:1 agenda is empty three times running	The most reliable early warning available to a remote manager, and the easiest to miss because an empty agenda makes for a short pleasant meeting.
They are always available, at all hours	Not commitment. Usually anxiety about being seen to work, and a reliable predictor of burnout. Address it explicitly.
They have stopped appearing in other people's threads	Isolation from the team, which is invisible to you unless you go looking.

FAILURE MODE · MANAGING THE GREEN DOT

Watching availability status, response times, or activity metrics as a proxy for performance. It measures nothing useful, it is obvious to the team within a fortnight, and it produces exactly the behaviour it purports to detect: people performing presence rather than doing work, jiggling the mouse, replying instantly to everything and thinking carefully about nothing.

It also crosses into monitoring, which is regulated in several jurisdictions and is not a manager's decision to take (§92). If you cannot tell whether someone is working, the problem is that you have not defined the output — which is a management problem with a management solution.

Trust and visibility when nobody can see the work

Two failures are common and opposite. Some managers over-monitor, because absence of visibility feels like absence of control. Others under-communicate, on the theory that leaving people alone is respect — and then people conclude they are invisible.

The resolution is to make the *work* visible rather than the person: clear outcomes, agreed checkpoints, and progress recorded where anyone can see it. Then you never need to wonder what someone is doing, and they never need to perform being busy.

On your side, remote managers must over-communicate three specific things that used to travel by osmosis:

- **Context.** Why the priority changed, what you heard in the leadership meeting, what is going on elsewhere. Remote teams starve of context and fill the gap with anxiety.
- **Your own state.** "I'm heads-down on the budget this week and slow to reply" prevents a fortnight of people wondering what they have done wrong. Silence from a manager is read as displeasure with remarkable consistency.
- **Recognition, in public and in writing.** Remote contributors are systematically under-credited because their work is less witnessed. Saying it in a channel takes ten seconds and is the main mechanism by which distributed people build a reputation.

The mechanics of a fair hybrid meeting

The inclusive-practice requirements are set at §128.6. Four mechanical details that determine whether they actually work:

- **One person, one screen — including people in the office.** A room of five with two dial-ins is two meetings. If anyone is remote, everyone joins individually. This is the single change with the largest effect and the one most resisted.
- **The document is the meeting.** Agenda before, notes during, decisions recorded in the same place. Anyone who could not attend loses nothing, and the time-zone question stops being a fairness problem.
- **Explicit turn-taking, chaired.** Remote participants cannot use the physical cues that get you into a conversation. Ask people by name. Watch the chat, and read out what is written there — a contribution in chat that the room never hears is worse than no contribution.
- **Nothing decided in the ten minutes after.** The corridor conversation as people pack up is where distributed teams silently become unfair. If something comes up, it goes back to the document.

Onboarding someone you will never sit next to

Remote onboarding fails at the informal layer — not the systems and the training, which are covered by SOP-HR-02, but the hundred things a new joiner would have absorbed by sitting nearby for a month.

- **Name the unwritten rules explicitly.** How decisions really get made, who to ask about what, which meetings matter, what "urgent" means here, how much polish a draft needs. Write it down; you will find it takes a page and saves three months.
- **Schedule the serendipity.** Six or seven short introductory conversations with named people in the first fortnight, arranged by you rather than left to them. Say what each one is for.
- **Meet daily for the first two weeks.** Fifteen minutes. New remote joiners accumulate small questions they will not raise in a weekly slot, and the accumulation is what makes the first month miserable.
- **Give a visible win in the first month.** Something small and real that appears in a shared channel with their name on it. Remote joiners have no other way to become known.
- **Say the quiet part.** *"You're going to feel out of the loop for about six weeks and that's normal, not a sign that it isn't working. Tell me when you're confused rather than waiting until you've worked it out."*

JUDGMENT CALL · CAMERAS

You cannot read a call of black rectangles, and the team is disengaged. Do you require cameras on?

A blanket requirement is a poor trade. It excludes people with legitimate reasons — a disability, a caring responsibility in the room, a home situation, or simply the exhaustion that is well documented and real — and it forces you into either an accommodation conversation you should not be having or a rule you will not enforce evenly.

Better: be specific about the occasions where it genuinely matters and say why. *"For our 1:1 and for anything where we're working through disagreement, I'd really like cameras on — I can't read a conversation otherwise. For everything else, do whatever works for you."* Then model it. If the underlying problem is disengagement rather than video, cameras will not fix it and the requirement will make it worse.

The proximity audit

Twice a year, spend twenty minutes on this. It is the only reliable way to catch proximity bias, because by definition you cannot notice it while it is happening.

List your team. For each person, against your own records: how many hours of your attention in the last six months; how many high-visibility assignments; how many times they presented to anyone senior; their last rating; whether they have been named as a successor for anything. Then sort the list by whether the person is co-located with you.

If the pattern falls along location lines — and it very often does, in teams run by well-intentioned managers who would have denied it — you have found something real, it is fixable, and it would otherwise have shown up in your promotion data two years from now with far worse consequences for everyone.

APPENDICES

A · Conversation Script Library

Opening lines for moments that arrive without warning. Borrow the structure, not the words. None of these replaces the required approaches at Employee Handbook §132, which govern the situations listed there.

Setting expectations and giving feedback

The moment	An opening that works
You are giving feedback for the first time to someone who has never had any	"I want to change how we work together slightly. I'm going to start giving you feedback much more often — small stuff, in the moment, both directions. It doesn't mean something's wrong. It means I'd rather you heard things from me in March than in December."
You need to raise something you have let go three times already	"I should have said this the first time it happened and I didn't, which is on me. I'm going to say it now because letting it run isn't fair to you."
Someone's work is fine but not what you needed	"The work is good. It's not what I needed, and I think that's because I wasn't clear about the outcome rather than because you missed anything. Can we redo the brief together so I don't do that to you again?"
You need someone to change how they behave in meetings	"I want to give you some feedback about the planning meeting. You made the point three times, and after the second one people stopped engaging with it. The point was right. The repetition cost you the room."
Someone keeps escalating to you instead of resolving it	"I've noticed these come to me rather than getting settled between you and Dan. I'd like to change that. What would you need in order to close it out directly?"
You are asking for more and know it is a lot	"I'm going to ask you for something that's genuinely a stretch, and I want to be honest that it is. Here's what it is, here's why I'm asking you, and here's what I'll take off you to make room."

Career, ambition and disappointment

The moment	An opening that works
Someone asks what they need to do to get promoted	"Good question and I'll give you a real answer rather than a general one. Give me until Thursday to think about it properly, and I'll come back with the two or three specific things I think the case would need."
Someone wants a role you do not think they are ready for	"I want to be useful rather than encouraging here. I don't think you'd get it today, and I'd rather tell you why than let you find out. Here's the gap as I see it — and tell me if you think I've got it wrong."

Someone's ambition is not achievable here	"I've been thinking about what you said you want. I don't think this team can give you that in a reasonable timeframe, and I'd rather say so than string you along. Let's talk about what your options actually are — including the ones that aren't here."
A peer was promoted and they were not	"I imagine today was hard. I don't want to pretend it wasn't. Can we talk properly on Thursday about where you are — not today, when it's raw?"
Someone is coasting comfortably and could do much more	"You're doing this job well and you could do it in your sleep in a year. I'd rather that didn't happen. What's the thing you'd find genuinely hard?"

Team, conflict and change

The moment	An opening that works
Two people on your team are in conflict	"I'm going to talk to both of you separately and then together. I'm not interested in who started it. I'm interested in what needs to be true for you to work together, because that part isn't optional."
Someone complains to you about a colleague	"Thanks for telling me. Before we go further — have you said any of this to them? I'll help either way, and I want to know where we're starting from." (If it touches on how they are being treated rather than what is being done, stop and route it — see Chapter 3.)
You are announcing a change you cannot fully explain	"Here's what's changing and here's what I can tell you about why. There's a part I can't discuss yet, and I'd rather say that plainly than pretend there isn't one. I'll tell you as soon as I can."
The team is demoralised and you have no fix	"I'm not going to stand here and tell you it's fine. It's been a hard quarter and some of the reasons are real. Here's what I can change, here's what I can't, and here's what I'm pushing on."
You need to say no to a request from your team	"No — and here's the reasoning, so you can tell me if I've weighed it wrong." (A no with reasoning is a decision. A no without one is an obstacle.)
You are new to a team that liked the last manager	"I'm not going to change much for the first two months. What I'd like from each of you is the honest version of what works here and what you'd fix if it were up to you."

Awkward and administrative

The moment	An opening that works
Someone asks you to keep something between you before telling you what it is	"Before you tell me — if it's something I'm required to pass on, I will have to, and I'd rather you knew that now. With that said, I'm listening."
Someone asks a policy question you cannot answer	"I don't want to guess on something that matters. Let me get you the right answer — I'll come back to you tomorrow."

Someone asks you to approve something you are not authorised to approve	"That's not mine to approve, and I don't want to say yes and then have it unwound. Let me find out who owns it and come back to you with a route."
You have to withdraw something you previously agreed	"I said yes to this and I'm now having to go back on it. That's a fair thing to be annoyed about. Here's what changed and here's what I can do instead."
Someone brings you a mistake they made	"Thanks for telling me straight away — that's exactly right and it makes this much easier to fix. Let's sort the problem first and look at what happened afterwards."
You need to end a meeting that is going nowhere	"We're not going to settle this today and we're spending time we don't have. Let me take it away, write up the two options, and we'll decide on Thursday."

APPENDICES

B · Manager's Toolkit — Templates

Working templates for the artefacts this handbook refers to. These are drafting aids, not Company forms — the official forms library is at Employee Handbook Part XIX and must be used where a form is specified.

B.1 · Role definition (before the requisition)

TEMPLATE

In twelve months, this person will have: [three to five outcomes, past tense, with measures]

This is a hire rather than a redesign or a development assignment because: [one sentence]

Level, and the evidence for it: [how much of this requires operating without direction, defining rather than solving, influencing without authority]

The one thing I will not compromise on: [competency]

The one thing I will accept as adequate and develop: [competency]

The one thing I can cover from elsewhere on the team: [competency]

Who else must interview and why: [names, and what each is assessing]

B.2 · Interview scorecard row

TEMPLATE — REPEAT FOR EACH OF FOUR TO SIX COMPETENCIES

Competency: [name]

Behavioural definition: [what this looks like in the work, not the abstraction]

Evidence that would satisfy me: [the type of instance I need to hear]

Question: [behavioural, asking for the most recent instance rather than the best]

Weak sounds like: [two sentences]

Adequate sounds like: [two sentences]

Strong sounds like: [two sentences]

Assessed by: [name]

B.3 · Evidence file entry

TEMPLATE — THREE TO FOUR ENTRIES PER PERSON PER MONTH

[Date] — [what happened, observably] — [what it demonstrated about capability, level or conduct]

Balance positive and negative entries. No characterisations. No references to health, leave, family, complaints or protected activity. Keep it in the Company system, one file per person.

B.4 · Note to file after a conversation

TEMPLATE

Date, duration, setting, who was present

What I raised: [the facts and dates, not the characterisation]

What they said: [their account, including the parts that support them]

What we agreed: [specific, measurable, with dates — theirs and mine]

When we review it: [date]

Sent to them on: [date]

If any part of this note would be uncomfortable read aloud, rewrite that part before you save it.

B.5 · Promotion case

TEMPLATE

Claim: [Name] has been operating at level [N+1] since approximately [date].

Instance 1: [date, scope, outcome, why this is level N+1 work]

Instance 2: [as above]

Instance 3: [as above]

The hardest part of level N+1 is [X]. The evidence they have done it is: [specific]

Corroboration: [what peers at the target level, partner teams or customers say — a direct quote is best]

The honest gap, and what I am doing about it: [one paragraph]

B.6 · Leave coverage plan

TEMPLATE — COMPLETED BEFORE THE ABSENCE BEGINS, SHARED WITH THE TEAM

Stops for the duration — [item] — [who I have told, and when]

Covered — [item] — [named owner] — [what changes in their own goals as a result]

Deputy for anything urgent: [name]

Contact preference agreed with the absent employee: [their answer, recorded before departure]

Goals pro-rated in writing on: [date]

Return date is not stated and not assumed. Restoration is directed by Leave Administration.

Return plan drafted by: [date] — pre-return message, week-one lightened, what-changed brief, week-six check-in.

B.7 · Team operating agreement

TEMPLATE — ONE PAGE, WRITTEN WITH THE TEAM, REVISITED TWICE A YEAR

- 1. Core hours and time zones:** [per person, in their own zone] · **Urgent means:** [X] · **Out of hours, do this:** [Y]
- 2. Response expectations:** chat [] · email [] · tagged comment [] · direct message []
- 3. Decisions made in writing:** [list]
- 4. Where things live:** [one location per category]
- 5. Meetings:** [which are decision, which are discussion, which could be a document; what happens if you can't attend]
- 6. How we disagree:** [norm — e.g. a call after two written rounds]
- 7. In-person time:** [frequency, and what it is for]

APPENDICES

C · Quarterly Manager Self-Audit

Twenty minutes, four times a year. Answer honestly; nobody sees it. This is not the compliance calendar — the recurring obligations you owe the Company are listed at Employee Handbook §131. This is the audit of whether you are managing well.

Attention and fairness

- List your team. Roughly how many hours of your attention did each get this quarter? Is the distribution defensible, and does it correlate with who is co-located with you, or with who you find easiest to talk to?
- Who got the interesting work? Who got the invisible work? Would either pattern embarrass you if it were published?
- Who has presented to someone senior this quarter, and who has not been in a room in a year?
- Is there anyone whose work I could not describe specifically right now?
- Have I made an exception this quarter that I did not write down the reasoning for?

The record

- Does every person have at least six evidence-file entries this quarter? Are they balanced, or only problems?
- Is there anything in my notes that is a characterisation rather than a fact?
- Is there anything in my notes that references health, leave, family or a complaint?
- Has anything been said in a conversation this quarter that was never confirmed in writing?
- Is there anyone about whom my written record would not support the view I actually hold?

Conversations owed

- What have I been avoiding saying, and to whom? How long has it been?
- Is there anyone who would be surprised by their current rating trajectory?
- Is there anyone I have privately concluded is not going to work out, who does not know?
- Did I cancel any 1:1 more than once this quarter, and whose?
- Whose empty 1:1 agenda have I taken as "nothing to discuss"?

Risk

- Has anyone on my team raised a concern, taken leave, requested an accommodation or discussed pay in the last three months — and am I making any decision about them?
- Is there an informal arrangement in place that should have gone through a formal process?
- Have I said anything this quarter about a person's age, health, family, accent or plans that I would not want quoted?
- Do I know the work state of every person who reports to me, and have I checked before answering any question from someone outside my own?
- Is my team's required training complete, and have I chased the overdue items?

Me

- What did I get wrong this quarter, and did I say so to anyone?
- What have I not delegated that I should have — and is the reason that I enjoy doing it?
- When did I last ask a direct report what I could do better, and did I get a real answer?
- Am I managing anyone whose success I am not genuinely invested in? What am I going to do about that?

APPENDICES

D · Where the Policy Lives — Cross-Reference Map

The complete index of what this handbook deliberately does not contain, and where the authoritative version is. If you need a rule, a number, a deadline or a procedure, it is here — not in the preceding chapters.

If you need...	Go to	Not to this handbook, which covers only...
Requisition approval, job description content, posting obligations, offer authority, pay-range disclosure, prohibited interview topics, selection documentation, offer rescission	Employee Handbook §14; SOP-HR-01 (§133)	Role definition, scorecards, sourcing contribution, split-panel decisions, closing craft (Ch. 4)
Background screening scope, FCRA sequence, fair-chance rules, reference handling	Employee Handbook §16; ISM SA-06 and §2.4.1 (screening before provisioning)	Nothing — this handbook contains no screening guidance
Interview plan requirements, common core questions, interviewer certification, panel composition, feedback timing	Employee Handbook §14.4–§14.7; §69.3	Question design, probing technique, note-taking, debrief chairing, work samples (Ch. 5)
Performance cycle dates, rating scale definitions, forced-distribution rule, calibration requirements, fair assessment obligations, review conversation requirements, disagreement route	Employee Handbook §§61–63	Evidence gathering, narrative writing, calibration preparation, delivery and reactions (Ch. 7)
1:1 cadence requirement, feedback structure, upward and peer feedback, development plans, career frameworks, required training list	Employee Handbook §64, §69	Diagnosis, 1:1 craft, delegation levels, coaching experts and high performers (Ch. 6)
Improvement plan prerequisites, contents, duration, outcomes and employee rights	Employee Handbook §65; Form 19.12 (§149)	Distinguishing capability from conduct and context (Ch. 10)
Internal application eligibility, promotion criteria, calibration, compensation placement, lateral moves, acting differentials, relocation	Employee Handbook §22	Readiness evidence, promotion case construction, the declined-promotion conversation (Ch. 8)
Progressive discipline sequence, immediate-termination categories, suspension rules, consistency register, documentation standards	Employee Handbook §66; SOP-HR-05 (§137); Form 19.13 (§150); ISM SA-10	Category diagnosis, severity calibration, conversation craft, repair afterwards (Ch. 10)

Termination review requirements, final pay deadlines, PTO payout, benefits, property recovery, references, rehire, exit interviews, reductions in force and WARN analysis	Employee Handbook §23; SOP-HR-06 (§138); ISM §2.4.3	Pre-decision testing, timing, the day-of runbook, reactions, telling the team (Ch. 11)
The required approach to a harassment report, a health disclosure, a pay question, a rating dispute, evident distress, or delivering a termination	Employee Handbook §132 — mandatory	General conversation architecture and eight different situations (Ch. 9)
The five non-negotiable manager obligations; what managers must never do alone; the manager calendar of recurring obligations	Employee Handbook §129, §131	The decision-register test and how to use your People Partner (Ch. 1, Ch. 3)
Complaint intake, investigation procedure, interim measures, anti-retaliation follow-up	Employee Handbook §13; SOP-HR-04 (§136)	Nothing — managers do not investigate
Personnel record structure, employee access rights, retention schedules, legal holds, privacy	Employee Handbook §21; ISM §7	What to write, how to write it, channel discipline (Ch. 12)
Every leave entitlement, eligibility rule, accrual, certification, state programme and interaction	Employee Handbook Part V (§§35–49); SOP-HR-03 (§135)	Inquiry discipline, coverage planning, team dynamics, return-to-work craft (Ch. 15)
Accommodation and the interactive process; religious accommodation; pregnancy-related accommodation	Employee Handbook §9, §10, §11; Form 19.04 (§147)	Nothing — managers route, they do not assess
Work location models, arrangement approval and change, home workspace and network requirements, remote injuries, required inclusive practices	Employee Handbook §128	Operating agreements, sync-vs-written, remote signal, hybrid mechanics, remote onboarding (Ch. 16)
Wage and hour: classification, timekeeping, overtime, breaks, off-the-clock work	Employee Handbook §17, §§28–31	Nothing — this handbook contains no wage-hour rules
Compensation structure, pay transparency, pay equity, bonus, equity, the review cycle	Employee Handbook §§25–34	Nothing — managers explain their own team's outcomes and route everything else
The statutory framework, state variation, and the multi-state comparison	Employee Handbook Appendix A (§§158–160); the current matrix on the People Portal	How claims are built and the seven manager-created patterns; behavioural triggers for CA and NY only (Ch. 13, Ch. 14)
Access provisioning, role changes, deprovisioning, access reviews, least privilege, privileged roles	ISM §2, particularly §2.4.1–§2.4.3; Employee Handbook §97; SOP-IT-01 (§139)	Nothing — follow the control
Security incident reporting and response; phishing simulation escalation; security awareness training and manager accountability for completion	ISM §5, §8; Employee Handbook §105; SOP-SEC-01 (§140)	Nothing — report within the hour and do not investigate

Acceptable use, AI usage policy and approval, data classification, monitoring	Employee Handbook §§89-95; ISM §7	Only the prohibition on introducing your own screening tools (Ch. 14)
Any form, template or acknowledgment required by policy	Employee Handbook Part XIX (§§145-157)	Drafting aids only, in Appendix B — which are not Company forms

IF THE TWO DOCUMENTS APPEAR TO CONFLICT

They should not, and this handbook has been written to avoid it. If you find a place where this handbook appears to tell you something different from the Employee Handbook or the Information Security Manual, **the policy documents control** — see Employee Handbook, Precedence of Documents. Then tell Employee Relations, so this handbook can be corrected at the next revision.

FEEDBACK ON THIS HANDBOOK

This is a first edition. If a chapter did not help you in a situation it should have covered, if a script did not survive contact with a real conversation, or if you handled something well using an approach that is not here — tell Employee Relations. The next edition should contain what managers actually needed.